

FOURTH SERIES
VOL. 131
No. 15



THURSDAY
26TH FEBRUARY, 2026

PARLIAMENTARY DEBATES

OFFICIAL REPORT

CONTENTS

VOTES AND PROCEEDINGS AND THE OFFICIAL REPORT— [Col. 1]

BUSINESS OF THE HOUSE— [Col. 3]

PAPER—

Report of the Joint Committee on the Ghana Accelerated National Reserve Accumulation Policy (GANRAP) 2026-2028— [Col. 58]

ORAL ANSWERS TO QUESTIONS—

Ministry of Lands and Natural Resources— [Col. 58, 66]

STATEMENTS—

(a) Population and Development: Shaping Ghana's Development— [Col. 92]

(b) Variation of the 2025 District Assemblies Common Fund Formula Passed by Parliament— [Col. 101]

MOTION—

Report of the Joint Committee on GANRAP 2026-2028— [Col. 125]

ADJOURNMENT— [Col. 172]

Correction of errors of substance may be made only on the floor of the House with the permission of the Speaker. However, correction of typographical or grammatical errors which Members suggest for the Bound Volumes which will be compiled at the end of the Meeting may be clearly marked in the Daily Report, and the copy containing the corrections submitted at the Editor's Office, Parliament House, not later than four clear days after the publication of the Daily Report.

BOUND VOLUMES of the Official Report (each with a comprehensive Index) are published periodically during the Session. There is no fixed subscription rate, but prices will be quoted on each publication.

*Published by the Office of Chamber Reporting
Parliament House, Osu, Accra.*

*Designed and Printed by the Publishing Department
Parliament House, Osu, Accra.*

©2026 Parliament of Ghana

THE
PARLIAMENT OF THE REPUBLIC
OF GHANA

FIRST MEETING, 2026

Thursday, 26th February, 2026

*The House met at the Chamber,
Parliament House, at 10:38 p.m.*

[HON FIRST DEPUTY SPEAKER,
MR BERNARD AHIAFOR, IN THE
CHAIR]

[PRAYERS]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, Correction of *Votes and Proceedings* and the *Official Report*.

**VOTES AND PROCEEDINGS AND
THE OFFICIAL REPORT**

Mr First Deputy Speaker: We have before us, the *Votes and Proceedings* of Wednesday, 25th February, 2026 for correction.

Page 1...7—

Yes, Hon Member?

Ms Comfort Doyoe Cudjoe: Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Yesterday, Mr Mohammed Adamu Ramadan was here.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: I saw him. Table, take note.

Page 8...15?

Hon Members, the *Votes and Proceedings* of Tuesday, 25th February, 2026, as corrected is hereby adopted as the true record of proceedings.

Now let us turn to the *Official Report*. We have the *Official Reports* of 18th February, 2026 and 19th February, 2026. First, let us look at 18th February, 2026 before that of 19th February, 2026. Hon Members, it is before you for your correction.

Hon Members, any correction?

[No correction was made to the Official Report of Wednesday, 18th February, 2026.]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Now, let us turn to the *Official Report* of Thursday, 19th February, 2026. Hon Members, it is for your correction. Any correction?

[No correction was made to the Official Report of Thursday, 19th February, 2026.]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Majority Leader?

Mr Mahama Ayariga: Mr Speaker, I thought we could take the Business Statement now. Even though we are concerned about Members getting to know the contents of whatever arrangements we are making tomorrow, we can take the Business Statement, then at the time of adjournment, we announce all the details relating to the logistics of tomorrow's programme

M First Deputy Speaker: Very well. Yes, Hon Member?

Mr Frank Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, with respect, if it is his pleasure, I would not oppose. But I would have thought that we can rather vary the order of Business and take the Questions, so that by the time that we are done with the Questions— All right, I am in support of the application.

The First Deputy Speaker: Very well. Then on that note, I will call on the Chairperson of the Business Committee, who doubles as the Leader of the House, to present the Business Statement.

BUSINESS OF THE HOUSE

Chairperson of the Business Committee/Majority Leader (Mr Mahama Ayariga): Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Introduction

Mr Speaker, the Committee met yesterday, Wednesday, 25th February, 2026, and arranged Business of the House for the Fifth Week ending Thursday, 5th March, 2026.

Mr Speaker, the Committee accordingly submits its report as follows:

Arrangement of Business

Formal Communications by the Speaker

Mr Speaker, you may read any available communication to the House.

Question(s)

Mr Speaker, the Business Committee has scheduled the following Ministers to respond to Questions asked of them during the Week:

No. of Question(s)

i. Minister for the Interior	5
ii. Minister for Roads and Highways	5
iii. Minister for Gender, Children and Social Protection	3
iv. Minister for Defence	1

Total Number of Questions	<u>14</u>
---------------------------	-----------

Mr Speaker, in all, four (4) Ministers are expected to attend upon the House to respond to Fifteen (15) Questions during the Week. The Questions are of the following types:

- i. Urgent – 0; ii. Oral – 14

Statements

Mr Speaker, pursuant to Order 91(2), Ministers of State may be permitted to make Statements on Government policy. You may also admit Statements by Hon Members in accordance with the Standing Orders of Parliament, Order 93.

Guidelines on Making Statements

Mr Speaker, the Business Committee is still concerned about the time spent on

Statements each sitting day contrary to Order 93(4) of the Standing Orders of Parliament. In view of this, the Committee proposes that four Hon Members in total may comment on a Statement for a period of three minutes per Member pursuant to Order 93(5) of the Standing Orders of Parliament. This is to control the time for Statements and clear the backlog of pending Statements.

In this regard, the Committee recommends that not more than an hour should be spent on Statements each day in accordance with Order 93(4) of the Standing Orders of Parliament. Attached again is a detailed Guidelines to making Statements.

Bills, Papers and Reports

Mr Speaker, in accordance with the Standing Orders of Parliament, Order 159, Bills may be presented to the House for First Reading. However, those of urgent nature may be taken through the various stages in a day, in accordance with Order 160 of the Standing Orders of Parliament.

Pursuant to Order 97, Papers may be laid during the week and reports from Committees may also be presented to the House for consideration.

Mr Speaker, the Business Committee took note of the pending Bills before the

House and therefore proposes to the House to prioritise the passage of the Bills.

Motions and Resolutions

Mr Speaker, Motions may be debated and their consequential Resolutions, if any, taken during the week.

Address and Debate on the Message on the State of the Nation

Mr Speaker, Hon Members are reminded that H. E. the President of the Republic will deliver to Parliament, a Message on the State of the Nation tomorrow, Friday, 27th February, 2026 at 10:00 a.m. Hon Members are reminded to be punctual and seated in the Chamber by 8:30 a.m.

Furthermore, Mr Speaker, a Motion to thank H.E. the President of the Republic, for the Message on the State of the Nation would be moved on Tuesday, 3rd March, 2026. Hon Members are therefore urged to participate actively in the debate.

The Business Committee, mindful of the need to thoroughly debate the Message by H. E. the President of the Republic, recommends the following time allotments for Hon Members to make contributions:

i. Majority Leader & Minority Leader	-	30 minutes
ii. Other Leaders	-	15 minutes
iii. Ministers/Deputy Ministers	-	10 minutes
iv. Leadership of Committees	-	10 minutes
v. Other Hon Members	-	5 minutes

In view of this, the Business Committee recommends that the debate on the Statement would commence on Tuesday, 3rd March, 2026 and the Hon Majority and Minority Leaders will conclude the debate on Wednesday, 11th March, 2026.

Mr Speaker, the Committee considered the issue of the number of Members to be recognised from each side of the House to contribute to the debate each day. The Committee, accordingly, proposed that the allotment of slots for debate on the Message should be based on the proportional composition of the House and subsequently, recommends a total number of 27 Hon Members to debate on each day, made up of 18 from the Majority Caucus and Nine from the Minority Caucus in the ratio of 2:1.

The Minority Members on the Committee, however, vehemently opposed the decision in rejection of the 2:1 ratio. The Committee accordingly submits the matter for the consideration of the House.

Sitting Time and Extended Sittings

Rt Hon Speaker, having regard to the exigencies of time, the Business Committee recommends that Sittings of the House commence at 12 noon to

ensure that business scheduled for the week is completed, as well as the debate on the Message is completed timeously.

Referrals at Committee

Mr Speaker, the Business Committee, is once again publishing the backlog of referrals before Committees, and urges Leadership of Committees to prioritise and expedite consideration of the referrals and promptly report to the House in accordance with Order 267 (4).

In view of this, Mr Speaker, an updated breakdown of pending referrals at Committee has been attached for the attention of Leadership of the respective Committees. A total of 294 referrals have been assigned to 24 Committees for consideration and report to the House.

Public Holiday

Mr Speaker, Friday, 6th March, 2026, is Independence Day. The day would therefore be observed as a statutory public holiday.

Conclusion

Mr Speaker, in accordance with Order 216 (2) and subject to Order 67, the Committee submits to the House the order in which the Business of the House shall be taken during the week.

10:48 a.m.

Tuesday, 3rd March, 2026

Roll Call

National Pledge

Statements

(a) **Mr Davis Ansah Opoku (Mpraeso)**: To make a statement on the Kwahu Easter celebrations and Tourism Development.

(b) **Mr Misbahu Mahama Adams (Mion)**: To make a statement on Ramadan, Extreme Heat in Northern Ghana a call for Climate action.

(c) **Ms Felicia Adjei (Kintampo South)**: To make a Statement on Proportional Representation and its Role in Promoting Gender Equity in Governance.

(d) **Ms Phillis Naa Koryoo Okunor (Awutu Senya East)**: To make a Statement on Introduction of Malaria Vaccines.

Questions

***635. Mr John Ntim Fordjour (Assin South)**: To ask the Minister for the Interior the total number of Ghanaians who became refugees in Ivory Coast and Burkina Faso during the Gbenyiri conflict and the plans of the Ministry to relocate them back to Ghana.

***636. Mr John Ntim Fordjour (Assin South)**: To ask the Minister for the Interior the total number of victims displaced during the Gbenyiri Conflict and what steps the Ministry is taking to restore the displaced victims to their homes.

***471. Mr Alexander Akwasi Acquah (Akim Oda)**: To ask the Minister for the Interior whether the Ministry recently presented some pick-up vehicles for the 24Hour Economy Secretariat, and the source of those vehicles.

***569. Mr Akwasi Gyamfi Onyina-Acheampong (Kwabre East)**: To ask the Minister for the Interior how the Ministry intends to monitor and evaluate the effectiveness of the new Independent Police Complaints Commission in rebuilding public trust and enhancing police professionalism.

***570. Mr Akwasi Gyamfi Onyina-Acheampong (Kwabre East)**: To ask the Minister for the Interior what specific actions have been implemented so far by the Ghana Police Service in investigating the violence that occurred during the rerun of the parliamentary elections in Ablekuma North Constituency.

Presentation of Papers

Motions

That this Honourable House thanks H.E. the President of the Republic for the Message on the State of the Nation which he delivered to Parliament on Friday, 27th February, 2026.

(Commencement of Debate)

Committee Sitings

Wednesday, 4th March, 2026

Roll Call

Statements

(a) **Mr Lawrence Agyinsam (Hemang Lower Denkyira):** To make a Statement on the Importance of Connecting Entrepreneurs in Micro, Small and Medium-Sized Enterprises Landscape in Ghana.

(b) **Mr Kweku Asante-Boateng (Asante Akim South):** To make a Statement on Tragic Road Accident around Juaso on the Accra-Kumasi Highway.

(c) **Mr Akwasi Gyamfi Onyina-Acheampong (Kwabre East):** To make a Statement on the Challenges of the Cashew Industry in Ghana.

(d) **Mr Solomon Kuyon (Krachi Nchumuru):** To make a Statement on the Urgent Need for a National Youth Development Fund.

Questions

***586. Mr Kwame Anyimadu-Antwi (Asante Akim Central):** To ask the Minister for Roads and Highways when Konongo Town Roads will be completed.

***663. Dr Zanetor Agyeman-Rawlins (Klottey-Korle):** To ask the Minister for Roads and Highways when the CMB – Abuja road will be completed.

***583. Mr Bright Asamoah Brefo (Bibiani / Anhwiaso/ Bekwai):** To ask the Minister for Roads and Highways the steps the Ministry is implementing to ensure the completions of the Awaso Town roads.

***598. Alhaji Alhassan Mumuni (Salaga North):** To ask the Minister for Roads and Highways the plans of the Ministry to construct the Vogyili – Kpashegu – Yapala Junction road.

***613. Ms Shirley Kyei (Atwima Nwabiagya South):** To ask the Minister for Roads and Highways when construction works will resume on the following roads: (i) Wiosu – Amanchia (ii) Nkawie – Nkranfoase (iii) Ntabanum Junction – Ntabanum.

Presentation of Papers

(#) Report of the Finance Committee on the Value for Money Office Bill, 2026.

Motions

(a) Second Reading of Bills

- Value for Money Office Bill, 2026

(b) That this honourable House thanks H. E. the President of the Republic for the Message on the State of the Nation which he delivered to Parliament on Friday, 27th February, 2026.

(Continuation of Debate)

Committee Sittings

Thursday, 5th March, 2026

Roll Call

Statements

(a) **Dr Mohammed Sherif Abdul-Khaliq (Nanton):** To make a statement on Emergency Care Deficit in Ghana.

(b) **Mr Charles Asiedu (Tano South):** To make a Statement on the Urgent Need to Revitalise the Ghana Cylinder Manufacturing Company Limited.

(c) **Mr Richmond Edem Kofi Kpotosu (Ho Central):** To make a Statement on the UHAS Leads Ghana in Global Impact Rankings - a Beacon of Health, Innovation and Development.

(d) **Ms Emelia Ankomah (Upper Denkyira East):** To make a Statement on the Occasion of the World Day of Social Justice, 20th February 2026.

Questions

***689. Ms Shirley Kyei (Atwima Nwabiagya South):** To ask the Minister for Defence when the Afari Military Hospital will be fully completed, commissioned, operationalised and handed over for use.

***677. Ms Gloria Owusu (Trobu):** To ask the Minister for Gender, Children and Social Protection the current status of investigations into the domestic violence case involving Harriet Amuzu, a 32-year-old woman from Ofankor.

***678. Dr Zanetor Agyeman-Rawlings (Klottey Korle):** To ask the Minister for Gender, Children and Social Protection when the AU Convention on the Elimination of Violence Against Women and Girls will be ratified and domesticated by the Parliament of Ghana.

***679. Ms Gloria Owusu (Trobu):** To ask the Minister for Gender, Children and Social Protection what measures the Ministry has put in place to reduce the increasing cases of domestic violence in the county.

Motions

(a) That this honourable House thanks H.E. the President of the Republic for the Message on the State of the Nation which he delivered to Parliament on Friday, 27th February, 2026.

(Continuation of Debate)

Consideration Stage

- Value for Money Office Bill, 2026

Committee Sitings

Friday, 6th March, 2026

NATIONAL HOLIDAY – INDEPENDENCE DAY

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, the Business Statement has been ably presented. It is now for your comments. I give the floor to the Minority Chief Whip.

Minority Chief Whip (Mr Frank Annoh-Dompreh): Mr Speaker, let me start off by thanking the Majority Leader who, for a reason, has to present the Business Statement today instead of tomorrow. Mr Speaker, 14 Questions slated for the ensuing week, clearly on the low side. However, for reasons not far-fetched, when we receive His

Excellency the President tomorrow for the Message on the State of the Nation, the cycle has been that in the ensuing week, we will start a debate, arguably for a week or five days, so one can understand. But I am particularly worried about a Question I have filed to the Minister for Climate and Sustainability Development. It has been three weeks. He has gone through the Motion and always the feedback has been that he is out of the jurisdiction; it has been almost three weeks now. I am not litigating on this matter, but I am saying that there are some underlying factors and reasons that are necessitating this Question.

Mr Speaker, not to belabour the point, Ghana has signed a number of carbon credits agreements. The last time we raked in over US\$2 billion as a result of our agreement with Switzerland. There are a few outstanding agreements that have the potential of bringing in money to our economy. The United Arab Emirates (UAE) has expressed interest and it is a huge potential area that we can cash in on. The Minister is always not available. I would want to recommend that the Leadership reach out to the Minister to make himself available to answer these Questions. There are only two Questions I have filed.

Mr Speaker, let me reference page two of the Business Statement presented by the Leader of the House and the Leader is proposing to this House the adoption of a proportional composition of the House in lieu of the debate. This matter is a nonstarter.

The greatest respect to the Leader; he raised this matter at the committee. I told him in plain words that no, our Standing Orders are clear. The Rt Hon Speaker had given a ruling on such matter; the same matter. So, if the Speaker gives a ruling on the matter and he is seeking to challenge it and clearly that is what he is seeking to do, he should come by Motion and he knows what to do. He cannot bring back a recommendation on a matter that has been decided upon already and say that the House will adopt this matter that the Speaker ruled on. That would be wrong. It is totally wrong and is an affront to our Standing Orders. Please do not do that! Do not raise the temperature this morning. This morning, we will help him execute Government Business. The Minister is here to answer his Question. Let us have peace. The Leader, should not raise the temperature unnecessarily because we are not going to accede to that call. We will not. If he wants the Speaker to vary his ruling, he should come with a Motion.

Mr Speaker, besides that, the Majority Leader is lamenting again. The backlog of referrals, 294 of them and he looks helpless. This backlog of referrals not being worked on. The Majority Leader had given some takeaways in terms of directive that Ranking Members and Chairpersons who still have referrals in their possession and they are not working on it, they are going to suffer some punitive measures. I followed up dutifully and I have copies of all the Business Statements. He had said that they will suffer some punitive measures. Last week, he varied it. The Leader varied it and said that the referrals are

294, therefore, he is begging them to work on it. He is repeating the same thing. We cannot do that. Majority Leader, get innovative. That is why we respect you as a Leader of the House and we have confidence in you. Do not come and tell us there is a backlog. We know there is a backlog.

Bring innovative measures of how we can track down on this backlog because it is happening under your watch. He can say that I am also in Leadership, but I am the Minority Whip. He is the Leader of the House and Leader of Government Business. So, forgive me I have to speak the way I am speaking but on this occasion, we cannot be sympathetic to him. He should come out with ways of which we can deal with this backlog because it is not the best.

Mr Speaker, apart from that, to be fair to him, he has been talking to the Chairpersons and the Ranking Members. But some of the Chairpersons are also working very hard. Some of the Ranking Members are working very hard.

10:58 a.m.

They bring their reports but we do not take them. Off the top of my head, I can name the Report of the Committee that Hon Collins Dauda chairs, for instance. It was programmed; the Committee has done its work but we never took it. The House Committee Report was programmed on the *Order Paper* but we never took it. So, that also raises a concern.

Mr Speaker, let me draw the curtains. Yesterday the Minister for Finance was in the House and I see that we have scheduled a Motion on the Statement he presented. Maybe the Minister for Finance should come back to the House. For instance, during his vetting, and one of the government policies which I have heard Government courageously say is the Sinking Fund. They said that it will help for us to put funds into the Sinking Fund. They said that the previous government that put GH¢138 million into the Sinking Fund did not do anything and that they were going to do more. As we speak, not a kobo, not GH¢1 has been put into the Sinking Fund. Nothing! These are the people's representative. The Minister must come back to this House on matters of the Sinking Fund which is very important for obvious reasons. He knows it, and as far as I also do know, he must come to speak to this concern. It is a matter that concerns the republic; it is important. Then capital investment—Last year, Government was short of about 55 per cent of capital investment. So, he must find his way to this House and to speak to such important matters.

Mr Speaker, having said this, I strongly want to register our protest for and on behalf of the Minority. We will not—I am referencing page 2 of the Business Statement presented by our respected Leader. Mr Speaker, we will resist with every strength in us. The Speaker has made a ruling on this matter that they want to speak on the Message on the State of the Nation based on proportion. So, if one person speaks here then three persons will speak there. What is that?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Minority Chief Whip, please do not sound too repetitive. You have made this point.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, I am concluding. Repetition is to emphasise. We on the Minority Side, Mr Speaker, we on your Left-hand Side will resist the oppressor's rule. The Leader is very good when it comes to procedure; we will not take that away from him, but he should know that if he seeks to challenge a previous ruling by the Speaker, he knows what to do. He should come by a proper Motion. If he wants to enter the Chamber, he should come through the door, but not through the window. We will not allow it. We the Minority Caucus will resist any proportional representation and speaking in this House.

Mr Speaker, having said this, I encourage Members to support adoption of the Report, but the part that says, Mr Speaker, with your leave:

“The Committee, accordingly, proposed that the allotment of slots for debate on the Message should be based on the proportional composition of the House and subsequently, recommends a total number of Twenty-Seven (27) Hon Members to debate on each day made up of Eighteen (18) from the Majority Caucus and Nine (9) ...”

It is not going to happen. Having said that, I encourage Members to support the adoption of the Reports and take out that part. It must be must be expunged from the Report and then we can adopt the Report.

Mr Emmanuel Armah-Kofi Buah:

Thank you, Mr Speaker. Let me thank the Leader for the Statement and to say how excited I am and looking forward to the Message on the State of the Nation to be delivered by the President. What a difference a year makes. We are excited about the Message on the State of the Nation that will be delivered tomorrow, that we are sure it will talk about the stability of the cedi, and the economy that is pointing to a direction that clearly shows that we are on the right path. We are excited to listen to the President talk about the state of a nation that has taken its leadership role in the African continent once again. We cannot wait for that message of hope on the state of the nation and where we are going. I urge all my Colleagues to be here wearing white to welcome the good news. *[Hear! Hear!]*

Mr Speaker, I listened to my respected Minority Chief Whip talk about raising temperature because the Majority Leader rightly—I know the Minority Chief Whip; he has been preaching on the principle of fairness. Every Member of Parliament walks in this House representing a constituency. We are a total of 275 Members of Parliament. Those they represent expect them to participate in every debate in this House. My Minority Chief Whip is making an argument and because I believe he believes in fairness, is he telling us that when 88 people on his Side against 196—*[Interruption]*—I am talking future numbers—88 against 187; if we subtract that number what happens to the other Members of Parliament? Is he saying that they should not speak? I think that

because he believes in the principle of fairness, it is only fair that, in fact, I think the Leader should have said that it should be four to one. *[Hear! Hear!]* The Leader simply said that we are going to proportionally speak and he is opposing it. They are 88 and we are 187, so it is only fair that every Member of Parliament is given the opportunity to contribute to the Message on the State of the Nation. So, the Majority Leader should be firm on this point. We support him. *[Hear! Hear!]*

Mr Patrick Yaw Boamah: Thank you, Mr Speaker. Last year this same issue arose and it was resolved by the Rt Hon Speaker. Members who were nominated by their caucuses were given the opportunity to make comments on the President's Message on the State of the Nation. It is a very important constitutional duty that the President will be performing tomorrow.

Mr Speaker, you are very experienced. You have been a Member of the African, Caribbean and Pacific States (ACP) Parliament.

11:08 a.m.

Can the Member give us one example of a Parliament where a ratio is used in determining how Members contribute to debate or make comments to debate? Mr Speaker, this is very alien because if we start adopting this —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Are you asking me a question for an answer?

Mr Boamah: Mr Speaker, it is a rhetorical question. I know you cannot answer the question. There is no Parliament in this world, any civilised Parliament for that matter, where ratios are used to determine the number of Members to comment or contribute to debate on the Floor. There is not one. Mr Speaker, if this model is adopted by this Parliament, there will come a time when ratios will be used to determine the number of Minority Members of Parliament (MPs) to make Statements and the number of Majority MPs to comment on the Statement. This same principle will be used to determine how Members contribute to Motions on the Floor.

Today, they are in the Majority. They have been in the Majority and the Minority before. Never in this Parliament or under the Fourth Republic has this thing ever been mooted. Hon Ayariga, we have to be very careful. This is a House of Parliament where Members from Akuapem South must be given the opportunity to comment on the Statement. Members from Akatsi South — where is my Brother from Akatsi South? I have not heard his voice. Lately, because of his duties, he does not even contribute to debates and Statements. We want the first Speaker, who has always been very vocal on the Floor, to be part of the debates. He must be given the opportunity. Hon Kwame Agbodza's Wednesdays are for Questions; he must stop and come and contribute to debates.

So, Mr Speaker, this model that is being mooted by the Chairman of the Business Committee must be struck out,

dismissed, and not encouraged. It is alien to the rules of the House and also to any civilised Parliament in this world.

Mr Speaker, I thank you very much.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Kwame Agbodza?

Mr Kwame Governs Agbodza: Mr Speaker, I realise our Colleagues from the other Side have been canvassing this *patapaa* position for a very long time. Even in Committees, ratio is what we use to populate the membership. What is different about that? This position they have taken is rather alien everywhere. Mr Speaker, if we follow this, one day they will realise that it will be difficult for some people to speak. This is completely out of order.

Mr Speaker, I propose that instead of saying we should speak for 10 minutes, since we do not want to use the proportion, every constituency must be given at least two minutes to speak. That is the only solution. Because I am not here representing the Volta Caucus; I am not speaking on behalf of the Volta Caucus. I am speaking on behalf of the people of Adaklu. I only happen to be a Member from the Volta Region, that is why I am a Member for —

Mr Speaker, the only fair way to deal with this is to say that every constituency must be given a time to speak. If it is one minute, then it is one minute. If it is two minutes, then it is two minutes. Anything apart from that would be alien, and it would be discriminatory towards the rest of our Colleagues. Mr Speaker, I would

even want us to take a vote on this matter and settle it once and for all, so that every constituency must be given an opportunity. If the MP decides not to speak, that is his or her own problem.

Mr Speaker, I arrest my case.

Mr Samuel Abdulai Jinapor: Mr Speaker, we are all looking forward to the Message on the State of the Nation tomorrow and the Business Statement correctly captures it on page 2. Indeed, the Hon Minister for Lands and Natural Resources has been attempting to give us a precursor of what is to be expected tomorrow.

Mr Speaker, expectations are varied, but I want to submit that if we conducted any research across the length and breadth of Ghana in general and among the youth in particular, two of the major issues I believe the country will be expecting to be addressed tomorrow will be the issues of unemployment and cost of living. Mr Speaker, there is absolutely no doubt about that. From Ellembele to Damango, the young men and women of our country are asking for employment. And the unemployment crisis in our country is a reality, is debilitating, and indeed, it is impacting the youth of our country in very negative ways. Therefore, the Minister should be reminded that in spite of all the things he talked about, the cedi appreciating and all of that, all those are welcomed. There is absolutely no two ways about that.

Macroeconomic stability is something that is welcomed. Of course, that is directly as a result of the post-COVID-

19 recovery plan the Akufo-Addo Government began implementing as far back as 2022, and that is also on record. Yesterday, the Minister for Finance was here to change, essentially change the programme introduced by Dr Bawumia, which is a Domestic Gold Purchase Programme. Mr Speaker, indeed, the Minister who is my successor, in whom I am quite pleased, would have seen from the handing over notes I gave him, that that Programme was initiated when I had the privilege of occupying that office. In fact, the Chief Executive Officer (CEO) of the Ghana Gold Board is on record to have made references to some of the letters I signed to invoke section 8 of Act 703 to give our country the preemptive rights to buy gold. So, Mr Speaker, that is a fact.

Mr Speaker, let me conclude on the call for ratio debating. There is no Parliament in the world where debates are conducted on a ratio basis. If it were the case, in the course of the Seventh Parliament, the New Patriotic Party (NPP) had 169 seats in this Parliament. And indeed, if the question was about the strength of the respective political parties, Mr Speaker, in the course of the Seventh Parliament, that ratio formula would have been applied. It is never done anywhere. I can well imagine and appreciate the frustration of the Majority Leader. That I can empathise with him. Because at the very beginning, some of us very modestly and respectfully made the point that the outcome of parliamentary debate is not proportionate to the numbers you have in a Parliament. It is proportionate to the quality of

contribution and the quality of debate. Mr Speaker, we have seen it before.

In the Second Parliament, from 1997 to 2001, the NPP Minority was some 64 Members in that Second Parliament. The National Democratic Congress (NDC) had a humongous Majority in that Second Parliament. Mr Speaker, in the end, the J.H. Mensah-led Minority stood up and rose up to the occasion and presented quality contributions in the Second Parliament, which culminated in the election of President John Agyekum Kufuor.

Mr Speaker, as I say, I empathise with the Majority Leader, but there is little we can do to help him. Perhaps he should find a workshop to ensure that the debate is at par, so that if we have 20 people debating from this Side and 20 people debating from the other Side, the debate will be at par. But it does not matter the numbers. Mr Speaker, even if he were to insist that only five NPP MPs should debate the Message on the State of the Nation, and 50 NDC MPs should debate the it, if he does not get his people to prepare and put their best foot forward, he will still have the same problem. And before long, Mr Speaker will be invited that even the Minority Leader should not be allowed to debate, and that we should leave the entire debate to the Majority Side. That will still not help if they do not prepare. And that will still not help if the quality of the debate is not strong.

Mr Speaker, I want to conclude by saying — and it is also the subject matter of the debate.

11:18 a.m.

If the matter on the table does not favour them, it does not matter the number of words they use. For example, if we were to debate about cocoa pricing in this Chamber, it does not matter if the ratio is five to one, they will not win the debate. If we were to debate about the price of electricity in this Chamber, it does not matter that they have a ratio of ten to one. They will not win the debate.

So, Mr Speaker, let us stick to the ruling the Rt Hon Speaker gave, which is that in every Parliament, one person speaks from the Minority, one person speaks from the Majority, just as we are doing now. But the gravamen of the matter is the quality of the debate, and it will not matter what ratio there will be. This Minority will continue to hold them accountable.

I thank you very much, Mr Speaker.

Mr Agbodza: Mr Speaker, I normally answer not less than ten Questions every week. I just realised it is only five Questions for next week. Why, do we not have enough Questions? Why would I prepare for only five Questions? So, Mr Speaker, if there are more Questions in the system, I want it to be, at least, ten Questions so that I come well prepared.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, let us move away from the tangential issues and move on to the Business Statement.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, I take a cue. But if the Minister for Roads and Highways had just been patient and spoken to the Hon Majority Leader regarding the observation he just made, he would have realised that it is because of the Message on the State of the Nation, that we have limited the number of Questions.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Minority Leader?

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, I have a couple of issues for the Leader of the House to respond to, and I am sure when this is well handled, it will help this House.

Mr Speaker, firstly, this is not the first time the Leader of Government Business introduced this proportional debating system. In fact, he brought this matter up and the Rt Hon Speaker ruled on this. There is a ruling on this matter. Therefore, I am saying that if he wants the decision to be reviewed, he knows what to do. Choosing a different approach is to lead you, Mr Speaker, into temptation, that the Rt Hon Speaker has made a ruling and he now wants to bring this matter up now that you are presiding. He wants to lead you into some difficult situation, Mr Speaker, and I know you would not want to be in any collision course with the Rt Hon Alban Sumana Kingsford Bagbin. We are supposed to assist the Chair, and that is the information I am providing. As for that application, it should be dismissed *in limine*.

Secondly, Mr Speaker, I want to bring up this matter of recruitment into the security services for the Majority Leader to take up, and if the House so desires, programme the Minister for the Interior. Mr Speaker, it is a matter that concerns all of us. Please lend me your ears. The methodology in the ongoing recruitment by the Ghana Immigration Services, Ghana Prison Service, Ghana National Fire Service and the Police Service has changed. What we have been told and have become aware of is that, the entire process is now centralised at the Ministry of the Interior. A private software developer by name TrybeNet has been tasked to create a data collection platform, which is empowered to run the process through the use of AI-generated aptitude examination with minimal visible involvement of institutional leadership of the affected services.

Mr Speaker, to explain, this AI-generated platform being operated by TrybeNet does not involve the Police, the Immigration, the Prisons, and the Ghana National Fire Services. What it means is that a person who is supposed to do an aptitude test does not answer questions in the area where he is applying. There is a software which is a centralised platform and, that is posing a difficulty, especially when none of the security chiefs and their management is involved.

Mr Speaker, let me give some numbers. What it means is that it is becoming expensive for would-be recruits in assessing the system. One, they need to buy a scratch card, have access to internet, have access to computer, and it is difficult. Especially so, when there are many areas in Ghana where internet access is a challenge.

What it means is that once they log in, the system over a short period, logs them out, even if they have connectivity problems. I am saying this because in my Constituency, people are approaching people for money to be able to have access. This is just at the beginning. If we do not handle this well, what it means is that the unemployed youth who are already desperate will end up spending so much money and will still not have access. It will compound their problems.

Mr Speaker, this is a matter that must be addressed, and it is not a partisan matter. It affects you and I in this Chamber. If your constituents already spend over GH¢2,000, and they do not even know which stage they will get to— With this AI-generated aptitude test, when they log you out, you need to pay for internet to get access again. Sometimes when we are raising an issue that affects all of us, people must pay attention. They should not always misconstrue it that when I get up, I am going purely partisan and attacking their Government. Hon Buah should bear with me and listen. Maybe because he is in Accra, he does not go to his Constituency to know what the youth are going through, so he should listen.

Mr Speaker, I would like to suggest—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Minority Leader, I agree perfectly with you. You are right to raise this point, but the stage at which you are raising it is what I am worried about. If your application is that we should invite the sector Minister to come and explain these issues, I do not have any problem with that. However, going into details with some specific allegations in the

absence of the Minister you are proposing to be invited is what I am worried about.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: We take guidance from you. There is a good reason why you sit in the east of the Chamber as the Presiding Officer. I take a cue and would not belabour the points.

Just that, Mr Speaker, I would pray that in view of the seriousness of this matter, may the Minister be invited for a Closed Sitting for this to be thoroughly discussed so that we would understand exactly the process. But as it is, it is costing so much money and it is becoming a burden on us because constituents are coming to us for money to go and buy access to internet; it is becoming problematic. Mr Speaker, that is issue one.

Mr Speaker, the second issue is that, the Majority Leader promised this House in his presentation of last Business Statement that the Minister for Finance will appear before us as a House and fully update us on that policy to reduce producer price of cocoa. *[Interruption]* Mr Speaker, could you change the sitting position of the Hon Minister for Roads and Highways? He is sitting in the seat of Hon Cassiel Ato Forson, and all he does is to make life difficult for me, and the Majority Leader will never come to my defence because it benefits him, and he encourages him to do that.

11:28 p.m.

Mr Speaker, the Majority Leader promised this House that he would ensure the Minister for Finance comes here to brief us on that decision to reduce

producer price of cocoa. Mr Speaker, he and I know that in opposition they promised GHC6,000 per bag. With the GHC3,100 they came to meet, they increased it and then reduced it to GHC2,500. Mr Speaker, the cocoa farmer in Ashanti Region, Central Region, Eastern Region, Western Region, Western North, Oti, Volta, Bono East and Ahafo Regions are suffering. In other words, *cocoa akuafoɔ a ɔmo wɔ Ghana, ɔmo anidasoɔ ara ne sɛ sɛbe price a yetua ɔmo per bag no, anka aban no beko so atua ɔmo saa. ɔmo ate so 10 million. Hwan na ɔbe kasa ama akuafoɔ no?* To wit— Mr Speaker, I am explaining it in English—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Minority Leader, with all due respect, you as a Leader of the House made a Statement on this matter and the Statement has been commented upon heavily if that cannot be described as a debate. So, for me, by the records of this House, you are please sounding repetitive.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, I am sorry, but because he made a promise which has become part of the records of the House so, I wanted to remind him.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, so if he made a promise which he did not refuse you have already raised that matter. We need to give him the opportunity to explain why he failed to deliver on his promise.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, very well. That is so. I was only giving a background. Like I said in twi: *cocoa akuafoɔ, ɔmo nim sɛ ewɔ sɛ ye tua*

ɔmo ka. ɔmo ate so 10 million. Sesiaa no hwan na ɔbe kasa ama cocoa akuafoɔ. ɔmo asem ye mɔbo. To wit, who speaks for the cocoa farmer? The cocoa farmer is in a very sorrowful state. A very sorry state. Nobody! The National Democratic Congress (NDC) Government that is supposed to speak for the cocoa farmer is not speaking for the cocoa farmer. Mr Speaker, the Majority Leader will have the chance to respond – I hope he is coming on a point of order.

Mr Ayariga — *rose* —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: I am compelled to recognise the Majority Leader.

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, we should not convert discussion of Business Statement, agenda for the week, into substantive discussions of matters involving sector Ministers who are not in the Chamber to respond. And also making allegations and claims that cannot be responded to because the relevant public officers are not in the House to respond. So, I think that it is important for us to exercise some discipline in the debate or commenting on Business Statements, so that we do not go on that tangent. Because, if the Minority Leader starts this way, then we all have to respond to every single issue that he has raised. Then we turn Business Statement into a full-blown weekly debate on matters that have not been properly brought to the House. Many of the issues that he is raising are issues that can only be brought to the House through a Question, Statement, or the Minister deciding to come and brief the House. But to go on a tangent of discussing them

into details when the Minister comes, will we give the Minister the opportunity to respond to everything during Business Statement and is that what Business Statement is all about? We would have bastardised what Business Statement is all about. So, I understand the Friday politics but there should be some limit to how it is done.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Majority Leader, I totally agree with you. Minority Leader, please take a cue.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, in fact, that was my last point. If he had allowed me, I would have completed. But, Mr Speaker, he, the Majority Leader should also know that when he gives his word, he must keep his word. He promised us that—
[*Interruption*]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Please, address the Chair.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, this is the time that you must show brotherhood. You have seen what he is doing.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: I did not hear him. He did not speak into the microphone. He is not captured by the *Hansard*.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, we have a pending Motion. The Motion on mass dismissal of Ghanaian youth. It is a review application. When it gets to such stage, the Majority Leader would not want to speak into the mic. He has been promising. Mr Speaker, this is

most unfair to the Minority. In any serious Parliament, the Minority must be heard. *[Interruption]* Then the Minority must be heard. Mr Speaker, that is not enough. *[Uproar]*

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Minority Leader, you are on your feet speaking and you are saying the Minority must be heard.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, it is not just being heard. Mr Speaker, you know that you must be seen to be heard in substance. We have brought a Motion which is national in character. The Majority frustrated that Motion. Mr Speaker, it has been over a year. Ghanaian youth who have been in the employ of state institutions, some since 2017, some since 2018, others 2020, 2024. Mr Speaker, all of them were dismissed en masse. We brought this matter up and lost our first application. We brought up a review application which was admitted. We moved the Motion and debated. The Majority Chief Whip did the first contribution for his Side. Mr Speaker, this Motion has stayed in our books on the *Order Paper* for over eight months. It is not good enough. Last week, the Majority Leader promised me and the entire Caucus that we would take it next week. He did the same thing two weeks ago.

Mr Speaker, today is Thursday. Tomorrow is Friday. The Message on the State of the Nation will take place so I am not sure we will be able to take it. Could the Majority Leader confirm whether he would programme this for

Tuesday? Mr Speaker, we have waited for far too long. These are employment rights that are constitutional. A right guaranteed by the Constitution. If Parliament cannot speak for these people, which institution can? Who can? Is it because the Majority Members are not affected by this mass unemployment situation that those who were dismissed do not come from their constituencies so they do not mind? Mr Speaker, it is important we address this thing.

Mr Speaker, my last point then I resume my seat. We want to know from the Majority Leader when the Minister for Labour, Jobs and Employment would bring the policy on one job, three shifts, to this Chamber. Since now, Ministers are bringing policies to this Chamber. It is not enough to talk about a so-called 24-hour economy. Even so, you created a legislation and a bureaucracy. That is not what we are talking about. The policy on one job, three shifts, which will include putting in place incentives for the private sector.

11:38 a.m.

The policy on the one job, three shifts, which will include putting in place incentives for the private sector, the youth in all the constituencies: Nungua, Adaklu, Bawku Central and Effutu are all waiting for the one job, three shifts.

Mr Speaker, I rest my case.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: I will give the floor to the Hon Minister for the Interior. But Minority Leader, are you not part of the people who made the law

to back the policy of the 24-Hour Economy in this House? You contributed to the making of the law.

Alhaji Mohammed-Mubarak Muntaka: Mr Speaker, thank you very much.

While I was driving here, I was listening to the Minority Leader. Mr Speaker, this is a House of records, and when someone like the Minority Leader speaks, it is good that he cross-checks his facts so he can put out accurate information. Because misleading the House by no other person than the Minority Leader is worrying.

Mr Speaker, he spoke about the recruitment process, and without necessarily responding to every single thing he said, let me say that we have made con men and women very uncomfortable with the recruitment process we are carrying out. *[Hear! Hear!]* We were all in this country when a recruitment process led to a Commissioner of Police in charge of Human Resource Management being dismissed from the Police Service because of extortion of money.

Mr Speaker, he spoke about the IT firm. I will charge him to check with the Public Procurement Authority (PPA) whether each of the services: Ghana Police Service, Ghana Prisons Service, Ghana Immigration Service and Ghana Fire Service, did not sign an individual contract with the service provider. These are facts he has to check, and he is a Minority Leader who will be responded to if he writes to PPA to find out whether

that was done and done properly. If he had written officially to any of their services, they would have educated him instead of standing in the Chamber of Parliament and misleading the generality of Ghanaians with his ignorance.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh — *rose* —

Alhaji Muntaka: Mr Speaker, he spoke about the aptitude test. There have always been aptitude tests, whether one is joining the Military, the Police, the Fire Service, or any other service. But what were they doing? They were doing it manually. We will see our children in—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Minority Chief Whip.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, ordinarily I would not do this. Hon Muntaka is somebody I respect. I came to meet him in office as a Senior Colleague and as a Whip, but I am coming under—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Minority Chief Whip, please address the Chair. You cannot be responding—

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, I will not respond. I will not even refer to the Standing Orders. I know there is a specific Order to refer to; Order 123. I could come under Order 123 (2) (a), but I will not. I would rather urge my respected Senior, Hon Muntaka, that to err is human. I mean, bottom line, we can all argue strongly, sometimes we take strong positions, but let us not veer off into foul language that will be offensive.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So, Minority Chief Whip, you are offended by the use of the word “ignorance”. Is that not so?

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, yes. He should steer clear of similar statements.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: We should fast-track so that we do not delay. We want to close early today. So, Hon Minister for the Interior, you heard him, he is talking about the use of the word “ignorance”.

Alhaji Muntaka: Mr Speaker, frankly speaking, I did not mean to be offensive when I used the word “ignorance”, but if one does not have knowledge about something, one is ignorant about it. But if he finds it offensive, I withdraw that.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well, proceed.

Alhaji Muntaka: Mr Speaker, I was just trying to note that it is something that he can always check. If he does not check and puts out what he does not know, he will be misleading the people and since he is uncomfortable with the word, fine—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, the word is now withdrawn. So, continue.

Mr Agbodza: Mr Speaker, the Minority Leader in his earlier statement said something along the lines of “If this were a ‘civilised’ Parliament”. This Parliament is civilised. By that same

ruling, the word used by the Minority Leader that if this were a “civilised” Parliament, must be expunged from the record because I am in a very “civilised” Parliament. I do not know what Parliament he was talking about. So that word must also be expunged from the records.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister for the Interior.

Alhaji Muntaka: Mr Speaker, I was talking about the aptitude test. There have always been aptitude tests. In 1996, when I tried to join the army, I had to write an aptitude test. Interestingly, I got to Medicals, someone went to tell my mother that I had run to Accra to join the army, and the only reason I did not join was that my mother was scared that I would join the army. I probably would have been either an ex-serviceman or still be in the army.

Mr Speaker, this is what happens with the aptitude tests. One physically goes to a centre to take the test, and then someone marks it. It was during the marking that people used to extort money from these innocent people, claiming they could pass them. What the Ministry of the Interior tried to do was to remove the human aspect and ensure it was done without human interference.

Mr Speaker, he spoke about internet challenges. He is forgetting that every one of them will have to travel from their village to either Accra, Kumasi, Bolgatanga, Sunyani, Takoradi, Cape Coast or Ho to write the examinations. However, today, we are making it easy

for them to sit in the comfort of their home or travel to the next village, town, or neighbourhood where there is internet to write it. Which one is easier? We have taken out the human interface. What is happening?

Mr Speaker, because I have been a member of the Pan-African Parliament, just like you, and I know that the majority of the African countries have stopped writing exams manually. In the African Union (AU) system, for the past 10 years, if one wants to join, they take an online exam. People do not realise the camera is facing them. If anybody tries to assist, it will take the applicant out because it will be deemed as cheating. If one tries to double-log so that someone will quote the question and answer it, the system detects it and takes the person out. That is why, even with that, we instructed that, because we are doing this for the first time, we will give all those who attempted it and were disconnected an opportunity for a mop-up. And that is why, currently, the mop-up is going on, to give them a second chance.

But 82 per cent of the people went through it without any problem. The 18 per cent who tried doing one fishy thing or another, we are giving them an opportunity to correct their wrongs, to know that the system is sensitive. First, I would have to upload their picture. The moment I give way, for example, to Hon Mahama Ayariga to sit and continue, it disconnects because that is not me. That is how the system is corrected. If he is saying that the young people of our country are so ignorant that they cannot use the internet, please, think again. They

are smarter than he thinks. 82 per cent of them have gone through the process without any problems. And it is a better system because it takes away all the human interference and all the corrupt activities that have been going on.

I can assure the Hon Member that the leadership of President Mahama will not sit when others who go through the hell of the process sit at home, while others go through in the name of so-called protocol. We are taking everybody through the system. They come and go through their body selection; we check their certificates; they would do the aptitude test, and do the medicals. Because, Mr Speaker, many of our young men go to training and die. But because they signed their undertaking, we do not even talk about it. Many people go for military training and die. They go for these other services training.

11:48 a.m.

I am sure most of my Colleagues who have been Ministers there could tell us; they go and could die because they have conditions that will not allow them to go for the exercise. Many of them in the past would not do it. We are insisting that they have to do all that, so that even if they have to be helped, for instance, the Minority Leader wants someone to be helped, they must go through the process and be qualified before they are helped. So please, stop deceiving the ordinary Ghanaian; we know what we are doing.

Mr Speaker, we are making sure that all the con men and women are taken

out. So that they do not get the opportunity to cheat. Just last weekend, two prison officers were arrested because they were trying to assist 14 applicants through the process. When we started, there were about four or five arrests and that is why we are not hearing cases of people duping others, because we are vigilant and we are watching. Yes, we should know our country has a challenge of unemployment, but in our reset agenda for the security services, one must have the minimum qualification before they can go in. We are not going to be dumping people there just like people have done. When we came, even people with diabetes were all under training; we had to get them out because they were not qualified to be there.

So please, Mr Speaker, without responding specifically to most of the allegations that he has made, I want to urge the Minority Leader that anytime he wants to speak about things that his Colleagues are in charge of, he should please get in and talk to them to get the facts. If he doubts them, he should put it in writing so that they will respond in writing and then he can speak to it.

Thank you very much, Mr Speaker.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin —*rose*—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Minority Leader, I want to plead with you so that we focus on the Business Statement. Hon Minority Leader —

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, he has made some personal statements —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, please, let us get it right.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, give me a minute to —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Minority Leader, please, both of you should hear me.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Very well.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: We are considering the Business Statement and we should focus on it. When the Business Statement is adopted and it is time for the Statement, then we can get up under Order 93 and raise a matter of urgent public importance.

Hon Nitiwul, you just walked in. This response, coming from the Minister for the Interior, was attracted by what the Minority Leader placed on record when we were considering the Business Statement. Sometimes, it is for a good reason that we try to limit comments on the Business Statement to matters arising from the Business Statement. But instead of focusing on matters arising from the Business Statement and add matters that are not included, these are the responses that are attracted.

That is why I feel strongly that matters relating to the Business Statement must be dealt with. So that if we get to the time for Statements and you get up by the leave of the person presiding and you have a matter of urgent public importance, you will be given the opportunity to do so. Then the opportunity will be given to another

person to also respond to the matter that you have raised. I believe that is the way we should be going.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, I would do exactly just that. But I want to put on record that sitting here in this Black Seat, I am not unaware of the responsibilities. I would never and the record should bear me out, get up to run down a Minister, neither would I say things that I know I cannot verify.

The Hon Minister knows me; I will not. Mr Speaker, as we may be aware, I have prepared a full Statement and in fact, I have actually cross-checked if the Hon Minister had been patient to listen to the exact words I used and how I approach this matter and how I even took a cue from Mr Speaker, he would not make submissions to the fact that the Minority Leader should cross-check and not mislead.

Mr Speaker, with respect to the Hon Minister as a Colleague, I would never take undue advantage of where I sit to run him or his Ministry down. I would not do anything to undermine my own credibility. I want the Nation to take me seriously and I want him to take me seriously.

Mr Speaker, the point I raised was well-founded in peculiar facts that when we get the chance to share, he will know that I am not misleading anybody. With that said, I take a cue from Mr Speaker. I would use the appropriate process to deal with this matter and I will furnish him with all the records I have and the peculiar facts I am raising for him to

know that I am not being personal, neither am I dealing with unverifiable facts. He may recall that yesterday, I beckoned him. I said I wanted to have a discussion with him because I wanted him to even have my Statement to read before I do it on the Floor of the House. Today, I only dealt with key issues about the cost to our constituents. I was not running him down with respect.

So, Mr Speaker, I think he misconstrued the gravamen of the submission I made prior to his entry into the Chamber, which led him to think that I am misleading or that I did not check my facts. I have copies of all those contracts.

Mr Speaker, he has been a Minority Leader and a Minority Chief Whip. He knows that when we are in opposition, we get information even far ahead than those in Government. So at least, he should give me that minimum respect; he has been here and he knows. When I was on their Side, there were things that he knew in Government that I did not even know.

So, Mr Speaker, as a Colleague, we are not obstructing; we want to help our nation. So please he should bear with me.

Mr Speaker, I rest my case.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Majority Leader, please, I will call upon you to respond to the issues raised pertaining to the Business Statement and then we move on.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu — rose —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Deputy Minority Whip, you know my style, that after giving the opportunity to your Leader, I do not look back. So, with all due respect, please, your Leader has spoken. I plead with you.

Mr Ayariga: Thank you, Mr Speaker.

First and foremost, there was a discussion about inviting the Minister for Finance and the Minister for Food and Agriculture to come and brief the House on the issues pertaining to the reduced payments to cocoa farmers. During that discussion, my Colleagues opposite insisted on making a Statement and even that day, I pleaded with them to wait until the Ministers were in the Chamber for them to make the Statement so that we could holistically discuss the situation. The Minority Leader insisted on making the Statement even before the two Ministers came into the House. Thereafter, I also made a Statement and indeed, I read the entire Press Statement of the Minister for Finance to this House, making it part of the record of this House.

Mr Speaker, I concluded that given that he had already made a Statement and we had extensively discussed that Statement, there was no need to summon the Minister for Finance and Minister for Food and Agriculture to this House to discuss anything relating to cocoa. But any Member is entitled to ask a Question about cocoa prices and if the Speaker admits that Question, and if the information requested is not in the public domain, then that Minister must come and Answer that Question.

11:58 a.m.

We know exactly how to get Ministers to come to this House. The practice where when I present Business Statement on Fridays, Hon Members get up and say they want Ministers to be summoned to this House to respond to issues, with all due respect, is not founded in any of our Standing Orders. It is not founded in any of our rules that on Fridays, Hon Members will get up on their feet and request a particular Minister to be summoned to respond to whatever they think that should be responded to. Where in our Standing Orders are they founding their request on? The rules are very clear and I thought everybody understood the rules. So I am not going to respond to any request that any Minister should be summoned here.

Now, let us look at what the Minority Leader did, raising an issue about recruitment in a way that amounted to a comprehensive Statement about the recruitment. I think that this is most unfair. The Minister responds to him, and instead of admitting his mistakes, he gets up and he wants to further undermine the Minister's statement. The Minister said he procured the service and that the various agencies participated. That the whole idea is to remove the human element as much as possible. I have been in this Chamber in the last one week and while were considering the Legal Education Reform Bill, 2025, the Minority Leader kept insisting on how we must introduce courses on artificial intelligence (AI), and information technology (IT), and how all the lawyers must begin to use AI.

The same Minority Leader who is insisting that all lawyers must use AI for their research, for legal work, is rejecting an attempt by the Minister for the Interior to use IT to resolve a problem that we have been confronted with for years. What double standard is this? He says that we must move towards removing the human element in order to deal with the problem of corruption, use IT in order to be more efficient and that we must cut the cost of young people who want to be recruited. Everything that the Minister has presented points in this direction. He is using IT; he is removing the human element and thereby fighting corruption effectively, and he is making it cheaper for the young people because they no longer have to travel long distances. What else could we ask for? What better arrangement could be put in place? He should show me.

Mr Speaker, I think we should be fair to our rules. On Fridays, yes, when there is a Business Statement, when we think an item should be included, just mention it. But then also they should not forget that there are ways in which to get Ministers to come to this House. This act of calling on me that I should summon a Minister every Friday, I am no longer going to accept it, because that is not the rules by which we get Ministers to this House.

Mr Speaker, I think the debate about the numbers that participate in the comments and debates during Message of the State of the Nation and the Budget Statement came up again at the Committee meeting. Even though the last time it was raised in this Chamber,

and the Speaker ruled that in the parliamentary system, normally both Sides are given equal opportunities, I also know that in a lot of Parliaments, every Member of Parliament (MP) has a minimum entitlement. Every Member has a minimum entitlement.

Go and scan through the arrangements in most developed Parliaments, and we will see that, for instance, when it comes to Statements, every MP is restricted to a number of Statements. One MP cannot come and bring 10 Statements; their slot is one. In addition, they are restricted to the time. The one slot that an MP has in every Meeting of Parliament, they must speak in five minutes. So, minimum guaranteed opportunities for everybody are guaranteed in every Parliament.

We come here representing different Sides. The more numerous the Side that one represents, the more issues that they have that must be put forward. If they are limited in their time, it makes it difficult for them to put out all those issues. And for me, I am not saying that every single day that we come to this Chamber, the Speaker should say for every matter that we are debating, let us have proportional representation. No. I said in this special instance of Message on the State of the Nation, every Member of Parliament must have an opportunity to have a bite. So, the arrangement that we have had in the past should be varied. Yes, I raised it before. Yes, the Rt Hon Speaker took a position. But if the House agrees on an issue and votes on it, I do not see how Mr Speaker can overrule this House. Mr Speaker cannot overrule this House. That is why it is contained in the Report of a

Committee. When the Report of the Committee comes, we vote on that Report, and we adopt the Report, the Speaker is bound by the Report of a Committee. It is not an issue that I have raised on the Floor that he has ruled on. It is the Report of a Committee recommending that this is how Business should be arranged. It is within the mandate of the Business Committee to make those recommendations.

I strongly believe that we should allow Members on all Sides to have an opportunity. Either we accept what we have proposed, or we revert to a system where when the Message on the State of the Nation is presented by the President, every single Member of Parliament should have a given time allocation. Even if it is two minutes or five minutes, every Member should have a time allocation. That way, everybody is given a fair opportunity to participate in the debate. That is my position on the matter. So, we have the proposal of the Committee.

I must put on record that this matter was objected to by the Minority Members of the Committee. Fortunately for them, there were only two that day at the Committee meeting. There were nine other Members who voted in favour of this arrangement. So this was supported by a majority decision of the Committee. We have presented the Report to this House. Let the House debate, as we have done. Let the House adopt the Report. If we adopt the Report, I believe that the Speaker definitely will accede to the arrangement. I am not saying it should apply to every deliberation in this House.

It is with particular reference to this Message of the State of the Nation that is going to be presented to us the tomorrow. That is the proposal.

In response to the Minority Leader's question that I promised to bring the Minister for Finance, and I did not bring the Minister for Finance. He also promised to bring the former Minister for Finance, and he never brought the former Minister to this House. He promised that he would bring the former Minister for Finance as far back as May, last year. Where is the Minority Leader running to? He promised to bring Ken Ofori-Atta to this House. Did the Minority Leader bring him to this House? *[Interruption]* He is on his way, coming from the United States of America (USA). He is busy fighting immigration there, to stay in the USA.

Mr Speaker, I want to urge Colleagues that I do understand that there is some advantage gained by their Side by giving equal space as my Side, which is two times their number. In fact, more than two times their number. The reason I continue to make this argument on my Side is that I agree with them that it is not the number of minutes that one has, but the substance of what one says. I agree with that principle. It is a sound argument. But in politics, how much airtime one gets is important in one's political projection. So, we are 187 on my Side, and we are given the same amount of time that they, who are 88, are given, then it means that they get the same time to project 88 while I am compelled to use the same time to project 187. It is clearly unfair. Mr Speaker, we are not going to accept it and we are

going to vote on this matter. When we vote on it, it is going to be binding on this House that this particular Message on the State of the Nation, we contribute on the basis of the number.

Mr Speaker, that is the position that my Side has taken on this matter, and this is what the Committee has recommended for consideration. As for the number of Questions that we are scheduling for next week, we agreed to reduce the number of Questions because next week we want to have the debate on the Message on the State of the Nation, we want to have the Bills considered, and we want to also have some of the Statements that have been pending and advertised for weeks now also taken. Also, we still want to create room for the various Committees that have referrals to present their Reports.

12:08 p.m.

So, in view of that, we calculated and came to a conclusion that, the only way we could do it was by reducing the number of Questions. So that, we can reduce the number of hours that we spend on Question time and stick to the one-hour rule in our own Standing Orders. So, to the Minister for Roads and Highways, this is why we cut down on the number of Questions for next week.

I believe all the issues have been responded to and I urge Hon Members to adopt the Report of the Committee.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, save that, Leadership of the House should engage on the ratio. Business Statement as presented is hereby adopted.

Hon Members, let me use the opportunity to admonish that today, we are talking about every democracy. In every democracy, when the two Leaders are given the opportunity to speak, we do not look back.

Yes, Majority Leader?

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, yesterday we referred the Ghana Accelerated National Reserve Accumulation Policy (GANRAP) document to the Finance Committee and we asked the Committee on Economic and Development to join them. The Report is ready and so we just want to lay the Report, so that we can come back to Questions asked of the Minister for Lands and Natural Resources.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Member?

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, I was actually not going to raise a matter with regards to the Business Statement, but I was trying to seek your guidance on something very important that I feel is wrong and that is in Order 71.

Mr Speaker, with your permission, I will read Order 71, so that you can guide me. Order 71(1) and (2) reads:

“1. Every Friday, the chairperson of the Business Committee shall present to the House, a statement on the business arranged for the following week.

2. Where the first Sitting of the Meeting precedes a Friday, the statement on the business arranged for the remainder of the week, where

possible, shall be presented on a day before the commencement of the Meeting.”

Mr Speaker, Order 71(1) is clear that the Business Statement can only be presented on a Friday. The only scenario that Order 71 gives variation on regarding the Friday, is to the effect that, if it is a First Meeting of a Sitting. So, I wanted to find out or seek guidance on what basis we are presenting and adopting the Business Statement, with today being a Thursday, when our Orders are clearly against it. This is the guidance I wanted to seek from you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, the Member is seeking for my guidance regarding Business Statement being taken on Friday. The combined effect of the Order read by the Hon Member does not make it static. So, if on Friday, the Message on the State of the Nation is going to be taken, by which it is not possible to take the Business Statement on the same day, there is nothing wrong taking the Business Statement today or on Tuesday. So, on the Rules that you have read, it is not static. Yes, Hon Member?

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, I do agree with him that there is a specific Order which sets out Friday. We had this debate somewhere last week. He should turn to Order 2, with no implied restrictions; Order 2 reads:

“Subject to the provisions of the Constitution and except as otherwise provided in these Orders, nothing in these Orders shall restrict the manner in which Parliament exercises or upholds its powers, privileges and immunities.”

So, when Parliament so deems it fit to change the date on which the Business Statement should be presented, nothing in these Orders will restrict Parliament from doing that. So yes, a specific date is scheduled, but Parliament can decide that for reasons of convenience, a different date will be used for presenting the Business Statement.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Member?

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, when you read Order 71(1), the word “shall”, is being mentioned. It reads: “...that every Friday the Chairperson of the Business Committee shall...” So, if it is the case that we are expecting the President tomorrow to deliver the Message of the State of the Nation, what prevents Parliament from taking the Business Statement, either before or after His Message.

Mr Speaker, Parliament is a House of records and for *Hansard* to capture—that is why I need your guidance. So that in future—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: First Deputy Minority Whip, the use of the word “shall” that you mentioned, is not in reference to the day, Friday, but in reference to the person who is to read the Business Statement.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, I am guided.

I think *Hansard* will capture your guidance. So that in the near future, if it is the case that we want to even present a Business Statement on Monday, nobody will argue on it. Mr Speaker, it is

convenient for the Majority Leader, so he does not want to apply his law properly.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Alhaji Habib Iddrisu, you have been in the House for some time. Is today the first day that the Business Statement is being taken on a day other than Friday?

The application is to vary the Order of Business for us to take the item numbered 9.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, there should be no objection to the taking of that Business. However, just to bring to the notification of the Majority Leader, on the page numbered 8 and 9, the items numbered 12 and 18, under the title “MOTIONS”. They have been on this *Order Paper* for a very long time. Majority Leader, I know you are particular about how we should do our work in this Chamber.

My concern is that, if we are not ready to take these Businesses, it should not appear on the *Order Paper*. We should be clinical as a House. For the past three weeks, we have this Motion always advertised on the *Order Paper*. Now, you just advertised this Business and you want to take it. So, it is a reasonable concern. Why did you advertise these ones earlier? For the past one month, you have been advertising them and just when this one came, you want to take it. Both are being advertised. The matter on the Pension Scheme and then the Auditor General matter.

We constituted a Committee to work on it. Why can we not take this Motion? I do not understand.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, in the absence of any objection to the application, at commencement of public Business, the item numbered 9. The Chairman of the Committee?

PAPER

By the Chairperson of the Committee—

Report of the Joint Committee on Finance and the Ghana Accelerated National Reserve Accumulation Policy (GANRAP) 2026-2028.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Member?

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, we may take the Questions now.

12:18 p.m.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: We turn back to the item numbered 8, Questions. Hon Members, the Minister is seated.

We then pose Question 547 standing in the name of Hon Akwasi Konadu, Member of Parliament for Manhyia North.

ORAL ANSWERS TO QUESTIONS

MINISTRY OF LANDS AND NATURAL RESOURCES

Effectiveness of Blue Water Guards in Protecting

Mr Akwasi Konadu (Manhyia North): Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the

Minister for Lands and Natural Resources the legal mandate, institutional structure and operational scope of the Blue Water Guards recently deployed by the Ministry and how effective they have been in protecting Ghana's river and water bodies from the continued destruction caused by illegal mining *galamsey* activities.

Minister for Lands and Natural Resources (Mr Emmanuel Armah-Kofi Buah): Mr Speaker, the mandate of the Blue Water Guards is to support the enforcement of existing mining and environmental laws by deterring illegal mining activities in and along river bodies and other water sources. The initiative operates under the supervision of the Ministry of Lands and Natural Resources in collaboration with the Minerals Commission, the Forestry Commission, the Water Resources Commission and the Environmental Protection Authority.

Mr Speaker, Article 257(6) of the 1992 Constitution and Section 1 of the Minerals and Mining Act, 2006 (Act 703) vest every mineral in its natural state in, under or upon any land in Ghana, rivers, stream, watercourses, throughout Ghana, the exclusive economic zone and continental shelf in the President on behalf of and in trust for the people of Ghana. The Ministry of Lands and Natural Resources has the mandate to sustainably manage and utilize Ghana's lands, forests and minerals for national development as provided for in the Minerals and Mining Policy of Ghana.

Mr Speaker, pursuant to section 100(1) of Act 703, the Minister has the mandate to generally supervise the proper and effective implementation of the provisions of the Act and its regulations.

Mr Speaker, in the exercise of this mandate and to stop further destruction of our water bodies by illegal miners, the Ministry in collaboration with the Minerals Commission launched the Blue Water Initiative which is in two parts; the de-chemicalisation of water bodies and the establishment of the Blue Water Guards to protect the water bodies from the devastating impacts of illegal mining. The Blue Water Guards operate in collaboration with other state actors such as the Minerals Commission, the Water Resources Commission, the Ghana Navy, the Environmental Protection Agency (EPA) and the National Anti-Illegal Mining Operations Secretariat (NAIMOS). This interagency liaison is fortified by sections 15 of the Minerals Commission Act 1993 (Act 450) and 3(2)(d)(ii) of the Environmental Protection Authority Act, 2025 (Act 1124).

Mr Speaker, while the policy oversight rests with the Ministry of Lands and Natural Resources, operational coordination at the local level involves the Minerals Commission working directly with the district assemblies as well as Police Commands to ensure effective implementation. In the discharge of their duties, the Blue Water Guards operate under a structured command system comprising a Commander and a Second-in-Command. They prepare daily work plans and are required to notify the local commander

of the Ghana Police Service of their movements. The Police Service works closely with the Guards to provide security support where necessary. These protocols have already been well established with the Ghana Police Service and the Naval Command.

Mr Speaker, the Blue Water Guards have enhanced surveillance and deterrence along river bodies and have strengthened collaboration between regulatory and security agencies at the district level. Their structured reporting system promotes accountability, while community sensitisation efforts have improved local awareness and cooperation in the fight against illegal mining and the pollution of our water bodies.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, any supplementary questions?

Mr Konadu: Mr Speaker, yes. Part of the Question had to do with the effectiveness of the Blue Water Guards in relation to our polluted water bodies and in particular reference, I asked this follow-up question. What has been the performance criteria or indicators that are being used to assess the work of the Blue Water Guards? I am bearing that question in mind as a preamble. As you know, doubling as the Minister for Environment, Science and Technology, the Environmental Protection Agency (EPA) currently says that for Birem river alone, they need about US\$35 million to do what they term as—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, when you engage in that

tangent, the actual Question that you have asked is lost. So, you have rightly asked the question. Yes?

Mr Konadu: Mr Speaker, I think the Minister is competent enough and I must build a basis for the Minister so that he will be able to answer the question effectively for Ghanaians to appreciate him. Probably that will not be. What has been the performance criteria that has been used by the Ministry to measure the performance of the Blue Water Guards, bearing in mind the continuous pollution that requires EPA to say they need US\$35 million to dechemicalise just one river body?

Mr Buah: Mr Speaker, in describing the work of the Blue Water Guards, I laid out the structure. I also talked about the commanding and report structure and that includes monthly reporting and supervisions and work performance and output. Those are all factored in on a monthly basis.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Any further questions?

Mr Konadu: Mr Speaker, the Minister talks about monthly reports and that is brought to the Ministry. Can the Minister be able to share with us, as he says he has monthly reports, what was and what is, so that it can therefore be used as a measure of the performance and effectiveness of the Blue Water Guards?

Mr Buah: Mr Speaker, I was trying to be very brief in laying out what the Blue Water Guards are. But the point I was trying to make was that because we have a laid out human resource structure, it

begins with training, retraining, discipline, supervision, and performance, rewards and recognitions for those who are performing. Those are being tailored and that is how we are tracking the performance of the Blue Water Guards and ensuring they are performing. We are tracking that on a monthly basis and making sure that where corrective actions are needed, it is done. Thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes. Final supplementary question, if any.

Mr Konadu: Mr Speaker, my question has to do with the impact on river bodies. Not necessarily the Blue Water Guards personnel themselves. The Answer given is a reliance on the Blue Water Guards themselves, their training, their retraining, and recognition. What is the impact of the Blue Water Guards activities and the performance criteria being used to assess their performance on our polluted river bodies?

Mr Buah: Mr Speaker, since the formation of the Blue Water Guards initiative, especially the guards in the various water communities have created the awareness to these communities about the need to make sure that we protect the water body. That is very important right now. One of the reasons we decided that we would go to the river communities is to make sure that the young people, in the spirit of the young pioneer, will understand the national duty to protect what is so fundamental, our water bodies and we believe that they are playing that very important role. They are also playing a very important coordinating role by being the eyes and ears of the security service, reporting on

timely basis on activities that are illegal and because of those very timely reporting, the security forces, the police, and the National Anti-Illegal Mining Operations Secretariat (NAIMOS), and even the Minerals Commission have intervened on a timely basis in a lot of areas. Reports of seizures of illegal equipment and arrests have all been possible in a lot of different river bases because of the Blue Water Guards.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: We then move to the Question numbered 353, standing in the name of Mr Duke William Allen Kwame Amoako-Atta Ofori-Atta.

Hon Members, before giving him the floor to ask the Question, I crave your indulgence to acknowledge the presence of our students from Pearl House Academy, led by Bosson Sena, National Commission on Civic Education (NCCE) municipal director. They are from Effutu Constituency; they are 68 in number.

[Students from Pearl House Academy were acknowledged.]

12:28 p.m.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: We also have Rom International School, led by James Abban Mensah, Headmaster. They are from Ningo-Prampram Constituency and are 56 in number.

[Pupils of Rom International School were acknowledged.]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: We have Ghana National Tailors and Dressmaking Association, led by Kojo

Esuman, NCCE patron. They are from Gomoa West Constituency and are 63 in number.

[Representatives of the Ghana Tailors and Dressmaking Association were acknowledged.]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: We also have Odokor MacLean Basic School, led by Grace Anderson, Assistant Headmistress. They are from Ablekuma North. They are 90 in number.

[Pupils of Odokor MacLean Basic School were acknowledged.]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: We also have Liz Faith Hills School, led by Amissah Emmanuel, Headmaster. They are from Domeabra. They are 61 in number.

Hon Members, on your behalf. I welcome them to the Parliament of Ghana and urge them to have a fruitful visit. You may kindly resume your seats.

[Pupils of Liz Faith Hills School were acknowledged.]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Duke William Allen Kwame Amoako-Atta Ofori-Atta, the floor is yours.

Mr Seth Osei-Akoto: Mr Speaker, I stand on Order 88 (3) and have been authorised by the Hon Member who is to ask the Question to ask the Question on his behalf.

ORAL ANSWERS TO QUESTIONS

MINISTRY OF LANDS AND NATURAL RESOURCES

Provision of Tree Lots to Fanteakwa South

Mr Seth Osei-Akoto on behalf of Mr Duke William Allen Kwame Amoako-Atta Ofori-Atta (NPP — Fanteakwa South): Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Lands and Natural Resources the plans of the Ministry to provide Fanteakwa South with tree lots under the “Tree for Life Initiative”.

Mr Emmanuel Armah-Kofi Buah: Thank you, Mr Speaker. Mr Speaker, the Fanteakwa South Constituency is a beneficiary of the Tree for Life Reforestation Initiative which was launched by H. E. President John Dramani Mahama in March 2025. Under this programme, the Constituency benefited from the establishment of 20 hectares of forest plantations. In addition, under the Enrichment Planting model, 50 hectares of plantation was undertaken in the Worobong South Forest Reserve within the Fanteakwa South Constituency.

This year, the Ministry will continue the implementation of the Initiative nation-wide, and the Fanteakwa South Constituency will benefit from free seedling distribution for wood-lot establishment, the reclamation of degraded mined-out areas, education and sensitisation.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Any supplementary question?

Mr Osei-Akoto: No, Mr Speaker. Thank you very much.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, this is constituency specific. We would move to Question numbered 456 standing in the name of the Hon Alhaji Nuridee Muhammed Mumuni.

Number of Excavators Seized by the Ministry

Alhaji Nurideen Muhammed Mumuni (NPP — Nalerigu/Gambaga): Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Lands and Natural Resources, the number of excavators that has been seized by the Ministry since the assumption of office by the Minister.

Mr Buah: Mr Speaker, since my assumption of office, a total of 500 excavators has been seized at various illegal mining sites country-wide. In addition, a total of 490 have been impounded at the Tema Port awaiting clearance. Thank you.

Alhaji N. M. Mumuni: My follow-up question, on 2nd July, 2025, the Administrator for Mineral Development Fund mentioned that 33 excavators were missing and on 3rd July, 2025 the late Minister for Environment, Science and Technology, my late senior brother, Hon Murtala Muhammed, mentioned that 40 excavators were missing. I want to find out from the Minister whether these excavators have been found?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, if your question were to be on a missing excavator, I would have allowed it. But your question is, how many excavators have been seized, and you have been given the number exactly.

Hon Members, I had cause to discuss the manner in which some questions are being posed with your Whips at the lobby. The Whips can attest to the fact that I share this view with them, that if your Question is about the number of excavators seized, and you are given the number, why would we be talking about missing excavators? So, let us just play by the Rules.

Alhaji N. M. Mumuni: Mr Speaker, we do not have the opportunity to hear some of these arrangements that you always have at Conclave. But looking at the follow-up question, it is related to the same excavator issue, and the Minister is ready to answer, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, will you take a cue? Your Question is simple. "To ask the Minister for Lands and Natural Resources, the number of excavators that have been seized by the Ministry since assumption of office of the Minister.". Now the Minister has come to give you the number. If your Question were to be on the missing excavators, then the Minister would have done his research work and bring you the information. So, Question time is not to take anybody by surprise. You do not ask a Question on the number of seized excavators and then turn around to be asking a supplementary question on missing excavators. There

are two different things, and it offends Standing Order 89. You are introducing a different matter. You are talking about seized excavators, then you are again talking about missing excavators. So, let us play by the rules.

Alhaji N. M. Mumuni: Mr Speaker, you know you are my best Friend, and I am guided.

But Mr Speaker, another question that I want to ask the Minister is that, are these missing excavators part of the seized excavators? The Minister is ready to answer.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: But the Minister, in his Answer, never mentioned missing excavators. So that is your own words.

Alhaji N. M. Mumuni: Mr Speaker, Ghanaians are watching us. Ghanaians are interested in this issue of missing excavators.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: If the Ghanaians are interested in that particular matter, you know how you should put your Question. There are some Questions that demand a yes or no answer. When the answer is given to you, definitely looking at the nature of the question, you would have difficulty asking a supplementary question. One instance is the question that you have asked.

Alhaji N. M. Mumuni: My very good Friend, Mr Speaker. I want to find out from the Minister whether these 500 excavators seized in the same location or

in different locations across the mining areas. How many were in each location?

Mr Buah: Mr Speaker. Those seized excavators have all been accounted for, and they are in different locations across the country.

Alhaji N. M. Mumuni: Mr Speaker, that is just one follow-up. Can the Minister give us the locations where these excavators are kept? Because we want to track ourselves, so whenever we see a particular excavator moving from those locations, we can alert the security agencies to do their work.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Nurideen Mumuni, sometimes I have a difficulty. We owe a fidelity to the rules. You asked for the number of seized excavators, you are given the number. These excavators are seized. The whole world is watching us. You now want the Minister to disclose to you the location of those seized excavators. Why?

Alhaji N. M. Mumuni: Mr Speaker, I do not see anything wrong with the Minister disclosing to this honourable House where the excavators are located.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Well, the whole world will see something wrong with it. So, your question is overruled.

Alhaji N. M. Mumuni: Because seized excavators are not illegal that we will say that we are doing something illegal.

12:38 p.m.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So, if you seize my item and you are now in a public forum saying that my item that you have seized, this is where it is kept, are you considering the security implications of it?

Alhaji N. M. Mumuni: No, Mr Speaker. There is absolutely nothing wrong with that.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Please, let us do the right thing.

Alhaji N. M. Mumuni: Mr Speaker, I cannot continue arguing with you on this issue. I am guided. Thank you very much for the opportunity.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: You are welcome. Yes, Hon Gloria Owusu?

Ms Gloria Owusu: Mr Speaker, thank you for the opportunity. Hon Minister, last year there were reports that 33 excavators were missing. Can you confirm to this House whether the excavators are truly missing, and if they have still not been found?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: The question is humbly overruled.

Ms Owusu: Why?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, let there be order. Hon Members, some Questions should be substantive Questions for the Minister to prepare the Answer to come and give. But for God's sake, this question is

seeking to know the number of the seized excavators. Nothing more, nothing less. The number has been given.

So, I will come to you, Hon Assafuah.

Mr Vincent Ekow Assafuah: Mr Speaker, I want to find out from the Minister for Lands and Natural Resources, out of the total number of seized excavators — and if I do the calculation, it is about 990. Out of this number, how many of them have been released to their owners? And those that have been released, how many of them were released out of a court order?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Please, kindly file a substantive Question.

Yes, Hon Habib Iddrisu?

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, in the last sentence of the Minister's Answer, he said: "In addition, a total of 490 have been impounded at the Tema Port, awaiting clearance." Minister, I wanted to find out from you whether those impounded excavators can also be termed as seized excavators. If it is impounded, is he going to do an investigation and give them the opportunity to clear it, or is he seizing them?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Minister? After that, I will go to Hon Suhuyini.

Mr Buah: Mr Speaker, I use the word "impounded" for a very good reason. Those impounded excavators are going through a process of verification through the Ministry of Transport in collaboration with my Ministry and the

Customs Division. Once they can certify that they were imported based on the guidelines that have been established, that is, they had approval before they imported it, and establish a legitimate company and the location where it is going, it would be tracked to that location and those impounded excavators can then be released to them. But those 490 excavators have been impounded, pending the process.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Minister, I ask this question because the Questioner sought to find out only about seized excavators. So, Minister, why did you include impounded excavators in your Answer when the question was talking about only seized excavators?

Mr Buah: Mr Speaker, I wanted to be very transparent to ensure that this House will be provided with all the information at my disposal. I thought it was important I did so. I am very happy to clarify as we go forward.

Alhaji Suhuyini Sayibu Alhassan: Mr Speaker, I want to find out from the Minister how many seized excavators were handed over to him when he assumed office. Because we know that the previous Government, his predecessor, also announced — *[Uproar]*

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, I think you have asked your question. I would advise you to file a substantive Question. Hon Members, let us move to the Question numbered 461, standing in the name of Dr Ebenezer Prince Arhin, Member of Parliament for Mfantseman.

Ratification of the Ewoyaa Lithium Agreement in the Mfantseman Constituency

Dr Ebenezer Prince Arhin (NDC — Mfantseman): Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Lands and Natural Resources the plans the Ministry is implementing to facilitate the ratification of the Ewoyaa Lithium Agreement in the Mfantseman Constituency.

Mr Buah: Mr Speaker, I am happy to report that after extensive consultations, the Ewoyaa Mining Lease was laid in this august House on 19th December, 2025 for consideration and ratification. It has since been referred to the Committee on Lands and Natural Resources for consideration and report to the House.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Any supplementary questions?

Dr Arhin: No supplementary questions, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: This is a constituency-specific question. Let us move to the Question numbered 518, standing in the name of Hon Francis Kwabena Owusu-Akyaw, Member of Parliament for Juaben.

Steps Implemented to Strengthen Minerals Exploration and Resource Estimation for Small-Scale Miners

Mr Francis Kwabena Berepong Owusu-Akyaw (NPP — Juaben): Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Lands and Natural Resources what steps the Ministry has implemented in

strengthening minerals exploration and resource estimates for the small-scale miners.

Mr Buah: Mr Speaker, to ensure sustainable mining, the Minerals Commission is collaborating with the Ghana Geological Survey Authority (GGSA), the University of Mines and Technology and the Ghana Landscape Restoration and Small-Scale Mining Project to undertake geological investigations in 30 blocked-out areas.

Mr Speaker, the GGSA has also completed preparatory works to embark on geological investigation on 20 blocks with the financial support of Ghana Gold Board. The exercises are being undertaken to delineate viable and suitable areas for small-scale mining. The GGSA is also actively mapping previously unmapped regions to identify new mineral deposits and replenish depleting resources. We believe that this collaboration will lead to the delineation of areas for resource estimates for small-scale miners in the coming years. So far, there are 180 designated areas across the country.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Any supplementary questions?

Mr Owusu-Akyaw: Mr Speaker, yes. I want to find out from the Minister's Answer, if it means that all the agencies mentioned are doing their own exploration in the various blocks?

12:48 p.m.

Mr Buah: Mr Speaker, I was very careful with the Answer.

I stated it very clearly that the Ministry is leading a collaborative effort among these various agencies to focus on geological investigation, to identify where the minerals are. And so, we are making sure that there is more coordination and collaboration among these agencies.

Thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Any further supplementary question?

Mr Owusu-Akyaw: No, Mr Speaker, thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: We then move to the Question numbered 548 which stands in the name of Hon Issa Salifu Taylor, Hon Member for Tarkwa/Nsuaem.

Status of the Refinery Project by the Ghana Manganese Company Limited at Nsuta

Mr Issah Salifu Taylor (NDC — Tarkwa/Nsuaem): Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Lands and Natural Resources to provide an update on the status of the refinery project by the Ghana Manganese Company Limited at the Nsuta site in Tarkwa Nsuaem and when the final approval from the Government will be granted to commerce operations.

Mr Buah: Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr Speaker, the Ministry received a proposal from the Ghana Manganese Company Ltd to establish a manganese

refinery plant in Ghana. The proposal covered the technical design and proposed production capacity of the refinery; estimated investment outlay and implementation timelines; expected economic and social benefits, including job creation and value addition within the mining sector.

However, the company has requested specific government intervention or facilitation to make the project bankable, notably in securing tax exemptions and waivers; reduction in port charges, and reduction in price and supply of gas to facilitate the construction of a manganese refinery. Consequently, the Ministry has constituted a Technical Committee made up of representatives of relevant stakeholder institutions to review the proposal. A series of meetings have been held with Ghana Manganese Company Ltd.

The Ministry of Lands and Natural Resources is coordinating follow-up discussions with key stakeholders to ensure all statutory, environmental, and fiscal issues are properly addressed before approvals are granted. The Committee is expected to complete its work by the end of the first quarter of the year.

I thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Member, any supplementary question?

Mr Taylor: Yes, Mr Speaker.

Mr Speaker, given that the Committee is expected to complete its work by the

end of the first quarter, can the Hon Minister indicate a clear timeline for when final approval will be granted and when commercial operations at the Nsuta site in Tarkwa Nsuaem?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister, any timeline?

Mr Buah: Mr Speaker, the construction of this refinery is a very critical project that will add to our value addition drive in the mineral space, and that is why Government is moving quickly to engage the company to ensure the committee completes its work. As soon as it is done, we will work with the company to make sure we follow all the legal processes is completed and approvals given for construction to begin as soon as possible.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, any further supplementary?

Mr Taylor: No further question, Mr Speaker. Thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Thank you. This is also a constituency-specific Question. We will move on to Question numbered 497 which stands in the name of Hon Isaac Boamah-Nyarko, Member of Parliament for Effia. You have the floor.

Update on Seized, Missing or Unaccounted for Excavators and Importation Regulations

Mr Isaac Boamah-Nyarko (NPP — Effia): Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Lands and Natural

Resources how many excavators have been seized since January 2025, the number missing or unaccounted for and what measures the Ministry is putting in place to regulate the increasing importation of excavators into the country. [*Hear! Hear!*]

Minister for Lands and Natural Resources (Mr Emmanuel Armah-Kofi Buah): Mr Speaker, since my assumption of office, a total of 500 excavators have been seized at various illegal mining sites country-wide. In addition, a total of 490 have been impounded at the Tema Port awaiting clearance.

Mr Speaker, again I wish to state categorically that no excavator seized is missing or unaccounted for. The Ministry has data on all the excavators seized and their location.

Mr Speaker, in furtherance to our efforts to regulate the importation and use of excavators, the Ministry of Lands and Natural Resources, in collaboration with the Ministry of Transport, the Driver and Vehicle Licensing Authority (DVLA), and the Minerals Commission, have rolled out a National Excavator Tracking System. This system provides a centralised national dashboard, geo-fencing capabilities, real-time alerts, and enforcement support. It also incorporates an import restriction regime, which establishes multiple layers of approval for the importation of earth-moving equipment into the country.

Mr Speaker, to import an excavator, an importer must first obtain approval or

a permit from the Ministry of Transport. Upon the arrival at the port, the DVLA registers the excavator before clearance. Thereafter, the Minerals Commission installs tracking devices on the equipment prior to its release from the port.

Mr Speaker, furthermore, Government has procured and deployed over 1,000 digital tracking devices to monitor and regulate the movement and use of excavators and other mining equipment nationwide in accordance with the provisions of the Minerals and Mining (Mineral Operations-Tracking of Earth Moving and Mining Equipment) Regulations 2020 (L.I. 2404). This technology-driven intervention is enhancing real-time monitoring, improving transparency, and strengthening accountability within the mining sector.

I thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, any supplementary questions?

Mr Boamah-Nyarko: Mr Speaker, I want to find out from the Hon Minister, what the Ministry is doing with the 500 seized excavators and the 490 impounded ones?

Mr Buah: Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr Speaker, the Government is working and collaborating with relevant agencies and we are in an advanced stage of discussions on the way forward on how these excavators can be utilised. I am not in a position to discuss that yet

because those engagements have not been completed. But once I am very clear about the way forward, I will come to this House and provide that information to Hon Members.

I thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, any further questions?

Mr Boamah-Nyarko: Mr Speaker, the Minister, in his response, indicated that they have incorporated an import restriction regime which establishes multiple layers of approval for the importation of earth-moving equipment into the country. I would want to find out from the Hon Minister what exactly goes into this import restriction regime.

Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister?

Mr Buah: Mr Speaker, prior to the implementation of this new restriction regime, excavators and other heavy equipment were not even registered with the DVLA; I am very happy to report that we now have a very robust registration regime working with the DVLA. I can also report that the DVLA, working closely with the Minerals Commission, has established a checking point at the port.

12:58 p.m.

And so those excavators that arrive, that is after you have received the permit,

and the stop point is the Ministry of Transport. If you are coming to import any heavy-duty equipment for road construction, you will get that approval from the Ministry of Roads and Highways. If you are coming to do mining, you will go to the Ministry of Lands and Natural Resources through the Minerals Commission, and if any other ministry, that will go to the Ministry of Transport.

Mr Speaker, so, we have a committee working together to ensure that the coordination exists and because of this robust regime, and the tracking that I have talked about, no excavator will move. As we speak, we have tracked over 1,000 excavators at the port. And we have geofenced them as well. So, if you say that your excavator is going to Tarkwa, Anglo Gold, for example, it will be tracked to Tarkwa. You cannot branch anywhere else and it will be geofenced to the mining site and that is how it is being tracked. In real time, we are monitoring those excavators at the Minerals Commission tracking room. I thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, your last supplementary, if any.

Mr Boamah-Nyarko: Very well, Mr Speaker. In his Answer again, the last but one paragraph, he indicated that Governments has procured and deployed over 1,000 tracking devices. I want to find out from the Hon Minister the percentage of the number of excavators in this country that are being tracked, or are tracked?

Mr Buah: Mr Speaker, I think it is a very good question. I know that since we began the implementation of this

programme, all the excavators that are now coming in the country are being tracked. Where we have the challenge is that those excavators that are already in the mines have not been tracked. But we are working with all these mining companies, DVLA and the Minerals Commission to also track those that are already in the system. I thank you.

Mr Vincent Ekow Assafuah: Thank you, Mr Speaker. On page 47 of the Minister's Answer, it says, "Mr Speaker, again, I wish to state categorically that no excavator seized is missing or unaccounted for. The Ministry has data on all the excavators seized and their location." An agency under your Ministry, that is Minerals Development Fund (MDF), has its Chief Executive Officer (CEO) in the name of Dr Hannah Bissiw on record to have said that about 33 of those missing excavators were missing. This is a glorious opportunity for you to clarify to the Ghanaian people. How do you reconcile both statements? Thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: The question is not admitted.

Mr Assafuah: The Minister is not even ready to go and answer. How is it not admitted?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, you will all agree with me that the Minister is not here to clarify a statement made by an agency's chief executive. Let us operate within our rules.

Mr Jerry Ahmed Shaib: Mr Speaker, thank you for the opportunity. Mr Speaker, sometimes it is just important that we remind ourselves that this is a House of records. And Ministers are endowed with the capacity to deal with institutions under them. Especially when the Minister has all the wherewithal to respond to those matters. Mr Speaker, I know for a fact that the Minister has an answer that would have even put this matter to a certain understanding and clarity and he was about to respond to the answer.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Jerry Ahmed Shaib, available Leader, show me the record of the House of the statement made by Hon Hannah Bissiw. You said this is a House of record.

Mr Shaib: Mr Speaker, I can share with you the video that has gone around—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Is that the record of the House?

Mr Shaib: Mr Speaker, I can share it with you. But Mr Speaker—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Majority Leader, let me hear you.

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, I think that given the nature of the issue, the allegations made and *et cetera*. The Minister is here so my plea is that if you will allow the Minister to respond to it, it will help—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Majority Leader, with all due respect, what I am trying to avoid is the Minister's words against the alleged statements made by Hannah Bissiw who is currently not in the Chamber to even utter a word. We are a House guided and we need to be guided accordingly.

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, the reason I am putting this plea is that the lady in question has issued a public statement denying the statement attributed to her. Number two, she is the CEO of an agency under the Minister and therefore, he is seized of the facts and can therefore respond.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Majority Leader, that is the more reason for which the question should not be allowed. Because you are saying that the lady in question has issued a public statement denying the allegation and such a person is not in this House. And the question being brought has nothing to do with any allegation concerning Hannah Bissiw in any manner whatsoever. So, per our rules, that question, for all intents and purposes, should be disallowed. Because Ministers are not asked questions based on allegations by another person.

Yes, Hon Nitiwul?

Mr Dominic Nitiwul: I do not intend to challenge your ruling or to challenge your reasoning. But I think because the Majority Leader has alluded to that particular matter, I will not have said anything. I think that it would be in the interest of the Minister to dig further into

that particular statement by the CEO. Because, Mr Minister, if you read the statement and the clarification as he has said, it is worse than to even say that the excavators were missing. So, I will urge the Minister to really dig into what happened because of what he said. This is because the CEO said that they first found 40 excavators and when they came back the next day, they met only seven. It is worse than saying that they were missing. So, I think that you should investigate it. I will accept what the Speaker has said, but the Minister should investigate that statement.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Well, the Minister can take that advice and investigate the proprietary or otherwise. But that is not a question I will definitely allow to be answered.

Yes?

1:08 p.m.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Thank you. Mr Speaker, I would like to find out from the Minister for Lands and Natural Resources whether he is aware that the CEO of the Mineral Development Fund made a statement that 33 Excavators were missing out of the 40 seized.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: The question is overruled. Yes?

Mr Philip Fiifi Buckman: Mr Speaker, I want to ask the Minister whether there are measures put in place to curb the situation where excavators were missing?

Mr Buah: Mr Speaker, taking lessons from the past and knowing the risk of excavators possibly missing or “flying”, we have taken very important measures to ensure that all excavators I see are equipped with security features, tracking devices and tracking numbers across the country. So those excavators that I have described have been properly equipped with features to ensure that they would not be missing.

I thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, Question time has ended.

Let me seize the opportunity to draw the House’s attention to Standing Order 88 (7):

“A Member, in asking the Question, shall not

- (a) address the House;
- (b) raise any argument; or
- (c) offer an opinion.”

It is on this basis that if you want to preface your question with an argument, you will be offending the Rules. If you want to say because of a, b, c or d, by way of offering an opinion, you will be offending the Rules. You cannot also address the House. “Where a Question has been asked and answered, no debate on it shall be permitted”.

Particularly in 89, I was taking it up with the Deputy Whip yesterday. And it reads,

“As soon as a Question is answered, any Member beginning with the Member who asked the Question

may, without notice, ask a Supplementary Question for further clarification of any matter of fact on the answer but a Supplementary Question shall not introduce a matter not included in the original question”.

Hon Members, let us take note of this particular Rule. You can ask a supplementary question, but a supplementary question must not introduce a matter which is not included in the original Question. So you cannot be asking a question about the number of excavators. When you are provided with a number, you can ask a question about missing excavators. Otherwise, you are introducing an entirely different subject matter.

On your behalf, I thank the Minister for attending upon the House to provide Answers to the Questions scheduled for him. Hon Minister, thank you very much. You are hereby discharged.

Yes, Majority Leader?

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, we will take two Statements without spending much time commenting on them. One on this Side and one on the other Side. Let us take Hon Edem’s Statement and then after that we will take his Statement. At the Business Committee meeting, we spoke about the need to at least provide space for Statements that have been advertised. And just after that, we are repeating the same thing. So, let us take one advertised Statement and then we can get to the next one.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, there should be no objection to that application except to say that I am coming under Order 93(1), and I have given the Speaker foreknowledge of it. So, the Leader should be informed accordingly.

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, the item numbered 8(c).

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, but he said he is coming under Order 93(1) to draw the House's attention to a matter of urgent public importance.

Mr Ayariga: Yeah, Order 93(1) does not say that when Mr Speaker admits that Statement, it should supersede any other Statement that is going to be made that day. So, a Statement can be made at the beginning, midstream or end of the sitting. We are not objecting to the Statement being made. Once the Speaker has admitted it, it will be made today. But we also agreed in the Business Committee that, over the last two weeks, we have been advertising Statements by mostly Backbenchers who come and sit here all day. Then, Leaders come and raise urgent matters to say that their Statements should be given priority and then the Backbenchers' Statements keep being delayed.

So we agreed at the Business Committee that I will not allow Leaders to come and stampede us on urgent Statements. We agreed, he was there, and I told him that I was not going to allow that. We will also allow Statements of Backbenchers to be taken. But today, we are saying that let us have a gentleman's

agreement to the Backbenchers' Statements, then he can also make his urgent Statement. I am not against it.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well, so which of the Statements do we take?

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, just to make a point for the record. It is not within the mandate of the Leader, with the greatest respect, to say that he will not allow a Statement to be made. Yes, he is the Leader, and I respect him, but it will not take the Leader to say that he will not allow the Statement to be made. It is the Speaker who admits the Statement. I am just surprised by the language he put out. It is not in his mandate.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Minority Chief Whip, are you talking about an admitted Statement or do you want to draw the attention of the House to a matter of urgent public importance?

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, I am sorry. I will not do this thing with you. I was at the Business Committee meeting when the matter was raised. In fact, I even raised the matter and said that as of the last advertisement, there were 19 Statements advertised and most of them stood in the names of Members who were first-timers. Then the Leader said that all right, then we should give priority to it. I agreed, but there should be a caveat. I am coming under Order 93 (1), and it is a matter of urgent public importance. I am not coming to stampede any Statement that has been advertised already. So, I agreed to what he was

saying. But for him to say he would not allow it, it is not within his mandate and our Orders do not give him that power. We respect the Majority Leader. We will defer to him, but it is not in his power to say that he will not allow the Statement to be made. He cannot do that.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: I think it was last week that the House reached some agreement following an incident involving Hon Ekow Assafuah. He had a Statement admitted on a particular subject matter and a Leader had a Statement on the same subject matter. The Statement of the Leader overtook that of the Member. It brought about some confusion, leading to the fact that some Members have their Statement process unduly captured on the Order Paper to be taken.

1:18 p.m.

However, Leaders will come with a Statement not captured by the *Order Paper*, and they want it to override the Statement captured by the *Order Paper*. We all agreed to be fair to all Members and to give a fair opportunity, so that they can also have a bite. Let us go by the rules so that if your Statement is not captured, you ensure that it is captured, and when it gets to your turn, the same will be taken. I think it was on this basis that the Leader is making his points. So, if the agreement of the House is in consonance with what happened last week, then we proceed to take Statement per the *Order Paper*, and my instruction is to take the Statement numbered 8(c), standing in the name of Mr Eric Edem Agbana, Member of Parliament for Ketu North.

Mr Eric Edem Agbana: Mr Speaker, thank you for the opportunity to make this Statement. But Mr Speaker, I want to humbly seek your guidance to make a prayer that I have two Statements admitted for more than six months, and if I am given the opportunity, I would rather want to take the item numbered 8(h).

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, you do not have a choice. I mentioned a Statement numbered 8(c), and that is what you have to take.

STATEMENTS

Population and Development: Shaping Ghana's Development

Mr Eric Edem Agbana (NDC — Ketu North): Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to make this important Statement on Population and Development, a matter that lies at the very heart of Ghana's socio-economic progress.

A couple of months ago, I had the privilege of participating in an intensive and enlightening workshop organised by the Parliamentary Population and Development Caucus, ably led by the indefatigable Deputy Minority Leader, Hon Patricia Appiagyei, and effectively supported by Hon Kwame Dzudzorli Gakpey. I wish to take this opportunity to commend their leadership and the efforts of all Members of the Caucus for facilitating such a timely and impactful engagement. The workshop was not only informative but also a powerful reminder of the intricate relationship between population dynamics and national development.

Mr Speaker, my motivation for raising this matter today stems from the deep insights gained during that workshop. Ghana's population is growing rapidly, with the youth constituting a significant proportion. This demographic trend presents both tremendous opportunities and serious challenges. If strategically harnessed, our youthful population can be a powerful engine for innovation, productivity, and sustainable growth. However, if neglected, it could result in rising unemployment, overstretched public services, and widening inequality.

It is, therefore, imperative that Ghana intentionally aligns its population growth with its broader economic development strategies. Parliament, in this regard, has a unique and critical role to play, not just through legislation, but by shaping national narratives, influencing public policy, and ensuring rigorous oversight in the implementation of population-focused programmes.

Mr Speaker, a key insight from the workshop was the evident gap in our current public policy framework. At present, there is limited synergy in how population issues are integrated into our development planning. This gap undermines the ability of the National Development Planning Commission (NDPC) to effectively formulate and implement population-responsive programmes.

Mr Speaker, the work of the Population and Development Caucus must serve as a catalyst for sustained, long-term action. We must commit to

empowering our people, especially women and young people, through access to education, reproductive health services, and meaningful economic opportunities. This is not merely a matter of benevolence, but one of national urgency and strategic importance.

In conclusion, Mr Speaker, I once again express my appreciation to the facilitators, while calling that as the youthful population grows, there is a need for all policymakers to take into consideration the fact that it is important to implement more pro-youth policies to support the growing population, especially among the young people.

Mr Speaker, the time to act is now. Let us work together to build a Ghana where population and development progress are in harmony, for today and for generations yet unborn.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, that is the Statement ably made. The Floor is now open for comments.

Hon Members, in the absence —

Yes, Hon Agbodza?

Mr Kwame Govers Agbodza (NDC — Adaklu): Mr Speaker, I rise to make a few comments about this brilliant Statement made by our Colleague.

Mr Speaker, it is true that in any jurisdiction, issues of population should account for any planning and projections, if we actually want that policy to succeed, whether it is education, health, security, roads or anything.

So, Mr Speaker, indeed, issues of our population should be at the centre of our planning and even the way we draw up our Budget. It is also important for us to know the population projections to know what to expect in terms of investment. Currently, everybody gets up and says our population is growing at about two or whatever it is. When the data comes up, we will also notice that today, somebody will say the population of Ghana is 32 million, another will say it is 35 million, because it is based on a projection. The census figure is different from the projected population, and the figures being quoted now are based on just a projection.

So, Mr Speaker, this is important. If I had my way, every policy that emanates from any institution or the State should show what population indices they are using to be able to do this.

So, I think the Statement made by our Colleague must be taken seriously. For instance, if we want to say we are building a road, or what should we be doing to the Accra-Takoradi Road in the next 10 years? It has to be based on a certain projection of the population, the number of vehicles that will be plying that road, and the kind of activities that the populace is doing at Takoradi. All these things should be considered. So, it is not only the numbers, but the details of the makeup of the population.

Mr Speaker, we have a lot of people come to us with one, two or three Master's degrees. When they are asked about the field of their Master's degree, and its relevance to the needs of our

country? Nobody answers that question. Maybe, if we paid attention to this, it would be important to find out whether we should allow even universities or some universities to continue to roll out certain programmes, because we are just producing people who have absolutely no idea what they will do.

Mr Speaker, the fact that, I have a Master's degree does not mean that I can automatically get a job. If I am looking for a job as a welder, and I have three Master's degrees in Economics, how useful am I to the job opportunity in welding? So, the issue of population, the makeup of that population, and the location of that population makeup must be taken very seriously. Because if we find out that some young people within a certain location have a certain age group and have a certain background in terms of education and skills, then in creating jobs, we know that a particular location is the best place for jobs. So, it will not be a political tool to say, because one is the Minister, they would put a certain factory in their village, when actually the skills are in the opposite village.

So, Mr Speaker, I think this is an important Statement, and if I have my way, I will even go as far as saying that this Statement should be referred to an appropriate Committee to further delve into the issues of population and how we apply population issues to the relevance of our national development.

1:28 p.m.

Mr Speaker, I wish that this Statement be considered as one of the Statements

referred to a Committee of Parliament for an in-depth study and then report to the Plenary for a decision.

Thank you very much, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity.

Mr Kwabena Okyere Darko-Mensah (NPP — Takoradi): Mr Speaker, we would like to congratulate the maker of the Statement for the brief introduction of the topic. As far as in Ghana, we know that our population is expected to grow to about 50 million in the year 2050, clearly indicating that there is more we need to do as a country to tackle key issues that affect our country.

The first issue, Mr Speaker, I believe has to do with the issue of unemployment. There are so many young people who are getting educated, getting skills, but lacking the ability to get jobs to do, which also puts a lot of strain on the adult population, especially dependency. So the adult who is working virtually is taking care of about four or five more other people who might not be their immediate family members. I believe that that is one area we need to put emphasis on. What is a curriculum that we would need to change to ensure that the young ones that are coming up are learning relevant skills that are applicable to industries, our homes and communities? That is the question we need to be asking.

The question we need to be asking the Ministry of Education is, what are they going to do differently this time around, up to 2050, to make sure that our people

are well positioned, that they are mobile enough to go anywhere in the world and be global competitors? What are we telling our Ministry of Education and other agencies? What programmes and policies are they putting in place to make sure that these young ones that are coming up get something to do, or can do something for themselves?

Mr Speaker, in this House, I think that consistently we have come to one conclusion, that it is going to be difficult for Government to provide all the jobs for our people. Therefore, self-employment and private employment, are the new ways that we can use in changing our countries. If we take all the developed countries that we have in the world, it is the private sector that has been able to generate employment for their people. Today, people talk about China, United States of America, and the United Kingdom. They are all private-led jobs that their people are engaging in. Therefore, what new mindsets do we instil in our young ones to start something on their own?

Mr Speaker, recently I have had the opportunity of speaking to one of our own professors in this House. He is a professor of psychology. What he told me is that these days, the youth even believe more in faith than doing something with their own hands. I believe that that is very dangerous, because we cannot continue to have this saviour mentality that we are waiting for somebody to come up with something before we do something for ourselves. With the rapid increase in population, if we are not careful, the demographic

dividend that we expect to get from our youthful population will be lost. If we compare the numbers in Africa, we see that Ghana, if we are not careful, it will be too late for us, because our population is not too young. They are virtually getting to their peak in their 35s. If we are not careful and we lose the next five years, it means that a lot of them are not going to get the benefit of the demographic dividend that we are looking for to get in this country. That is very dangerous.

Mr Speaker, if we take the population growth rate of this country, we are looking around 2.9 per annum, which is quite high. I mean, if we take other countries like China, initially people were complaining that the numbers were too high. But now, they have opened up the gates, that they need the younger people, because the other ones have become too old. If we go to Japan, it has become another major difficulty. I believe that we need to strategically rethink our training programmes and our mindset change programme. In fact, our psychology needs to be different, especially the psychology of creating value.

We need to start teaching it in all our schools from the basic—In fact, I believe that we have to start from the Junior Senior High all the way to Senior High School and then to the university. The mistake we have been doing in this country is that we allow our children to go all the way to university when they have formed their habits already therefore, training them and retraining

them become a difficulty. But if we start early, at a younger age, knowing the population growth is still going on, I believe that a lot of them will find their own pathways along the line and make sure that this country benefits from the demographic dividend.

The last but not least issue I want to raise has to do with the issue of the environment. I believe that the environment, if kept well, will be able to sustain a lot of our young people. One area I believe that we are all looking up to is the area of agro-processing and agriculture. Mr Speaker, it is high time we start looking at our own mindsets and how to assist the youth to be able to enter this field. Mr Speaker, the former Commissioner for the African Union H. E. Dr Nkosazana Dlamini-Zuma said something striking and I have kept that in my mind. She said that she wanted to see the cutlass and the hoe museum pieces. I believe that she was right.

If Africans are finding it difficult to enter the agricultural space, I believe that we should be able to develop new technologies, new autopilot systems, and new aquaponics that the young people can safely and easily jump on and create the next billionaires in agriculture and agribusiness space. I believe that it is doable. Today, in other jurisdictions where loneliness is prevalent, they are creating robots to take care of lonely people. I believe that if we have the fertile lands and we want to get the best out of agriculture, we should also be able to import technology into our society and be able to do well for ourselves.

With these few words, Mr Speaker, I would like to thank you for the opportunity to add my voice to the Statement made by the Hon Member.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Leadership? *[Pause]*

Very well. We then move to another Statement, and this time we take that of Hon Annoh-Dompreh. Hon Leader, is that the agreement? Yes.

Variation of the 2025 District Assembly's Common Fund Formula Passed by Parliament

Minority Chief Whip (Mr Frank Annoh-Dompreh): Mr Speaker, I rise pursuant to Standing Order 93(1), and with your leave and the indulgence of the House, I raise a matter I consider to be of urgent public importance, and further pray for some consequential directives in this regard. Mr Speaker, I have painstakingly investigated this matter and on my own come to some conclusion. However, I do not hold a complete repository of knowledge, hence I want to air the matter and get the buy-in of Members and for us to come to some good conclusion on this matter.

Mr Speaker, last year, as the practice has been, this House passed the 2025 District Assemblies Common Fund Formula, and the variables involved – Mr Speaker for want of time, I do not have to go through it – are defined in this document. The overarching subject area matters that the Fund was meant to deal with. Then, subsequently, we got hold of

a document that, Mr Speaker, with your leave, is captioned as “Approval of Guidelines for Utilisation of the District Assemblies Common Fund for the Year 2025”, emanating from the Ministry of Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs. This is not a Regulation; it is a guideline. We have also taken time to look at the Local Governance Act, 2016 (Act 936) which gives some powers to the Minister for Local Government Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs to issue some regulations. However, the Act does not permit the Minister to redirect and also give specific allocation in terms of percentages, how the funds should be allocated. That power is exclusively given to this House by Article 252. Hence, there is a question of our powers being eroded away. There is a concern about separation of powers, the Executive veering its hand into our authority and powers given to us by this Constitution.

1:38 p.m.

Mr Speaker, just to conclude on this matter, the guidelines give some eight areas with percentages and the total sums up is 100 per cent. Government Flagship Programme, design and construction of the 24-Hour Economy Model Market for which twenty-five per cent has been allocated or earmarked. They allocated these percentages to these: Health Facility which is at least two CHPS compounds, 10 per cent; educational facilities, 10 per cent; Water, a minimum of 10 boreholes, 10 per cent; environmental sanitation, solid and liquid waste management, 10 per cent;

administrative including monitoring and evaluation, 5 per cent; school furniture, 10 per cent; and the completion of legacy project, 20 per cent. All these sum up to some 100 per cent.

However, if one looks at allocation in the Statement and the formula that was approved, the guideline is a significant departure from the formula that was approved by this House. So, I think we may be setting a very dangerous precedent. Also, our constitutional powers eventually may be eroded and we would be setting a bad precedence for the future.

Hence, this has been my preliminary investigation report that I found. I am amenable to an absolute investigation by a Standing Committee of this House to come out with the facts and for us to give finality to the same matter.

So, Mr Speaker, I would not want to further drag this matter. I appeal to you to consequentially refer this matter to the Standing Committee on Local Government and Rural Development, for them to investigate thoroughly and come and apprise this House on same matter. This is for us to either adopt the Report of the Committee, take a decision or otherwise.

Mr Speaker, it is to firm up and to confirm our parliamentary jurisprudence and also to give meaning to separation of powers. What is meant to be done by Parliament cannot and should not under any circumstance be compromised for any other arm of government or agency of state. This is fundamental, important

and I make this point devoid of any paranoid mind. But just to say that we must get to the bottom of this matter as a House and to give finality to this matter once and for all.

I thank you, Mr Speaker, for the treasured space.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Majority Leader?

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, this matter is easily settled by just reading the Constitution and nothing more. The Article 252 of the Constitution says:

“1. There shall be a fund to be known as a District Assemblies Common Fund.

2. Subject to the provisions of this Constitution, Parliament shall annually make provision for the allocation of not less than five per cent of the total revenues of Ghana to the district assemblies for development and the amount shall be paid into the District Assemblies Common Fund in quarterly instalments.”

Mr Speaker, the task of Parliament is simple and it is to make sure that not less than 5 per cent of the total revenues is allocated to the districts. So, our obligation is to make sure, that amount is set aside for the district assemblies. Then the subclause 3 says:

“3. The moneys accrued to the District Assemblies in the Common Fund shall be distributed among all

the District Assemblies on the basis of a formula approved by Parliament.”

So, we ensure that five per cent is allocated. Then, we ensure that there is a formula for distributing the money to the districts by way of a formula. That is a formula that we approve. The formula basically takes into consideration certain factors such as, whether you are a metropolitan or a district assembly, whether you are a municipality, your population, your landmass, whether you are a rich or poor municipality, all those are in the formula.

Now that is the formula that is brought to us for us to distribute. When that is done by Parliament, we have finished our job. Now at the district assembly level, what the Government and the Ministry for Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs decide with them—Ultimately, it is their decision as assemblies. But the central government gives them guidelines on how to spend the money.

Mr Speaker, I do not see how that, compared to what we saw in this country, where a significant chunk of the money was squandered in Accra. Not too long ago, when the moneys were squandered in Accra and the assemblies got absolutely close to nothing—This Government now says 80 per cent of the money must hit the accounts.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Majority Leader, the maker of the Statement is up?

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, I had come under Order 93(1), with deference to the Leader. Order 93(5) is clear and it reads:

“A Member may comment on the statement for a period not exceeding five minutes, and the comment shall not provoke debate.”

The latter comments and observations put out by the Leader is offensive of this part of the rule. Mr Speaker, I implore him to pull the brakes on the Leader and let him know that, he must speak within the confines of the rules. He cannot provoke debate to say that the money was squandered in Accra and he does not provide evidence. What is that? If he has evidence of moneys being squandered in Accra, he should provide same or otherwise withdraw those statements. They are offensive of our rules. He cannot do that. He should lead by example. He is the Leader of the House and he is saying the money was squandered in Accra. He should provide evidence of that. Otherwise, he should withdraw those statements and make his contribution.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Majority Leader?

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, I am the Chairperson of the Committee on Independent Constitutional Bodies and as Chairperson, we have records of how moneys were spent in the last eight years. If he wants us to conduct an enquiry into this matter in this House, we would do it,

so that the whole country will see how the moneys were squandered.

Mr Speaker, it is a known fact and that is the basis of the promise of the National Democratic Congress (NDC) in its manifesto, that 80 per cent of the money must hit the accounts of the assemblies. As we have it now, 80 per cent of the money is sent directly to the assemblies. The record is there and they are using it.

All these guidelines seek to do is to make sure that when moneys are sent there, the abuse of the money, which we saw at the central level, is not visited on the money at the district level. So, we do not just want to give money to the assemblies, then they would do whatever they want with the money. That is why Government has sent guidelines to the District Chief Executives (DCE) to build schools, markets, CHPS compounds, kindergartens, drill a certain minimum number of boreholes and then deal with the environment. Then a certain amount should be spent on sanitation. These are the core items contained in the guidelines.

Indeed, if citizens see that the monies that are sent to the assemblies are indeed used to address these issues, they would continue to support the assemblies and to pay their property rates so that more development can come. There is nothing absolutely wrong with these guidelines. He has not shown any legal provision that has been violated.

In any case, in this House, we were here when even the amount that was to be given to the assemblies, were not

given. What did we do? We went to the Supreme Court. Do you think that giving guidelines to the assemblies to use moneys properly violates the Constitution?

1:48 p.m.

There is another avenue. It is not the business of this House to investigate those matters. We are not the Supreme Court; we are not the ones to interpret the Constitution. So, if they think that there is a constitutional violation, they should go to court. Ask for the policy, ask for the directives, ask for the guidelines. I can assure them that the guidelines have been sent. We do not need any investigation. I can confirm that the guidelines have been sent. So, if they are asking that we should do investigation to find out whether it is true, I am saying that it is true, that guidelines have been sent to the Assemblies and the details of the guidelines are exactly what they read

So, the only issue for determination is whether those guidelines are legal or illegal. That is the only issue for determination. That is the only issue for determination and they know where to go and seek that determination. They know where to go to. We went there, and we got a ruling that showed us how the allocation to the District Assemblies should be computed. Including oil revenue. We went to court. They are free to go to court. This is a court that is impartial. This is a court that will give a verdict in favour of even the Minority and they would come to this House and celebrate the verdict. So, they are free to go to this same court.

Mr Speaker, we have issued guidelines to the Assemblies, we will issue it next year, we will issue it the year after, and we will monitor to ensure that they comply by those guidelines. Because this is the surest way to ensure that when monies are sent to the Assemblies, those monies are indeed used for the welfare of the people. Because there is a practise where monies are sent to Assemblies, and a chunk of the money is spent on administrative expenses. District Chief Executives (DCEs), Chief Directors, Directors, are always running to Accra to attend a seminar and they are drawing on that money. So, at the end of the year, when we do the computation, we find out that the monies sent to the Assemblies, have all been consumed on administrative matters, on travels, on conferences, and *et cetera*. That is why this Government is saying, no, when we send 80 per cent of the money to them, we expect them to build this number of schools, this number of CHPS compounds, drill this number of boreholes, and construct a market. These are the standard things that you must do with the money and the debt, the projects that the previous government commenced and left, a percentage of it must be used to pay for the expenses of those projects. Then they can only spend a small fraction of the money for administrative expenses, not more than five per cent.

Mr Speaker, I now know Assemblies that are getting close to 10 times what they ever got when the New Patriotic Party (NPP) was in government. The records are there as well. I do not think that there is an issue. We have issued the

guidelines. There is no denying that we have not issued guidelines. We have issued guidelines. The guidelines are as indicated by him. He is free to go to court and challenge the guidelines. I do not think this House should waste its time setting up a committee to enquire and investigate any matter. Nobody is denying anything.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, it is quite unfortunate—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, I think the indication is not for me to take comments, but to end it so that we can do Government Business. Majority Leader, is that the indication?

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, I thought you had signalled that you had given me the opportunity to speak.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: I would give you the opportunity to speak. I just need an indication on this—

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: He just spoke. We have to respond to him. I have to respond to a lot of the things he said. They are not true.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: No. I am asking the number of people who comment on the Statement. That is the indication I am seeking.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, we have agreed on two on each Side.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes. So, when I have Members, I am confirming.

Is that the indication? This is not to prevent you from speaking.

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, we agreed on one from each Side. How did we handle the earlier—Mr Speaker, the agreement was one from each Side so that we can move to the next item. Now, one from each Side means that when he makes the Statement and I speak, that is the end of the matter. That is one each because he has made the Statement and I have responded. That is one each but if—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Majority Leader, he is offended by the use of the words “squandered money”.

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, to squander money is to spend the money.

Mr Speaker, we would do two from each Side. We are ready to go.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well. You have made your Statement. It is now two from each Side so one more.

Mr Annoh-Dompkeh: Mr Speaker, let it be known that I do not have any personal interest in this matter and for the Majority Leader to say that we have issued a Statement. In the first place, he did not issue the Statement. It was the local government for the record.

Mr Speaker, for the record, when he says they have issued a Statement, is he part of the Executive? He is not. I have not invited him so he should sit down.

Mr Speaker, he is not the one who issued the guidelines.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Minority Chief Whip, if you are inviting him, he will get up.

Mr Annoh-Dompkeh: Mr Speaker, allow me to speak.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: You asked him a question.

Mr Annoh-Dompkeh: It was a rhetorical question. He knows. Hon Colleagues, with the greatest respect to this House, we need to be concerned about this matter. This is a matter that is not supposed to receive partisan approach at all. I do not have any special interest in this matter. I am raising this matter purely on the grounds of patriotism. Now, when the Majority Leader says they have issued the guidelines, he did not. This is not directed at him, why is he sweating? He is not the Minister for Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs. The guidelines were issued by the Minister for Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs. For the record, it was issued by—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: The Majority Leader is on a point of order.

Mr Annoh-Dompkeh: Mr Speaker, when I came on point of order, you said I should wait for him to finish. Why would he want to come on point of order?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: I may not give him the opportunity just like how I gave you the opportunity.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: No, Mr Speaker, when he was speaking, I had a lot of point of orders. But you asked me to wait. Let him also wait. We are all subjected to the same rules. No, wait, sit down and wait. I am saying that these guidelines were issued not by the Majority Leader. The guidelines were issued by the Minister for Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs. So, stop shielding the Minister or taking responsibility for something that he did not do. He forms part of an arm of Government, the Legislature. I am saying that to the extent that a guideline is being issued by a Minister to undermine a formula that has been passed by this House, and he does not see anything wrong with it, I am sorry, he does not see anything wrong with it? Now, what I am simply saying—I am not calling for the formation of any committee. We already have a standing committee, a Committee on Local Government and Rural Development. I am saying that to the extent that the guideline is a departure from the formula we passed, it constitutes an illegality. It is not right. It is not right and we must go into this. The House must take a decision. They can use their numbers to pass whatever they want to pass. But to the extent that the thing is wrong, we must investigate into it.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: But do you want the House to take a decision on the Statement?

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, I gave you prior notification that I said that—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: No, you said the House should take a decision.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Yes.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: But there is a method by which the House takes decisions.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, that is also known and you can also give consequential directives.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Consequential directives are different from the House taking a decision.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: My preamble to the Statement had been, among other things, to call for a consequential directive from you and that was the engagement I had with you. If it is your pleasure that it should be done, fine.

1:58 p.m.

If it is not your pleasure, let the House subject it to—We can politicise this Statement, that is fine, but it will come back to haunt us. For him to say that in the previous administration, money was squandered in Accra, we have asked him to provide further and better particulars, and he has failed to do that. He is the Majority Leader; he is supposed to carry this House along. So, if he does not have evidence, he should not allege.

Mr Speaker, I invite you to expunge that portion of his statement, “Moneys were squandered in Accra”, he says that and he just goes away. It should be expunged. It cannot be part of our

records. If he has evidence, let him provide same. He can support the Minister on the Regulation, that is alright, but this thing will come back to haunt this House. Our powers as an independent arm of Government are being eroded and he does not see anything wrong with that. I am totally surprised. Mr Speaker, I thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: The agreement is that we should take one on each Side, so I will then give the floor —

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, that was the second contribution. Because when you raised the issue, he said yes, he will speak. When you asked who was the second person to speak, he said he will speak. So that is a second time.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, frankly speaking, I do not see this to generate any debate. So, let us all be guided as such in the language that we use and then we will move forward.

Mr Dominic Bingab Aduna Nitiwul (NPP — Bimbilla): Mr Speaker, we are Members of Parliament sent by our people as representatives, so our interest is to speak on behalf of our constituents. The Statement raised by the Minority Chief Whip is a very serious Statement. We should look at it from that angle.

Mr Speaker, this House has a convention where we pass a formula. The Common Fund Administrator accompanied by the Minister will come to this House, present his formula to us and give us what exactly the money will be used for item by item, project by

project. We passed it and, in fact, we get the resources to monitor exactly what has been presented to us on behalf of the people, to be sure that what the Government, through the Administrator and the Minister, has said is the correct thing.

Mr Speaker, if after all this, we now have a situation where an administrative fiat by the Minister, outside what Parliament itself has agreed and is aware of and is known to, is approved and the attention diverted completely from what Parliament has said, I think that it is a very serious matter. We all know and we have acknowledged that it is a good thing they have done to send the resources to the district; that is not in contention. Last year we said it and this year we have said it. In fact, during the debate of the formula we all acknowledged it. So, it is not something new to anybody that we are sending the resources down.

The previous government for which I served as Minister decided to cap Common Fund and Ghana Education Trust Fund (GETFund) and use some of the resources to do things in Accra like buying District Road Improvement Project (DRIP) equipment that my good Friend, the Minister for Roads and Highways, is now using, building 100 courts for the Judiciary for the first time and different other things. But that is alright. That is the decision by the Government then.

I think that what he has said, that we have a formula that is known to this House, and that we have also gone to

inform our constituents that this amount of money will be used for this up to 100 percent, which of them are we now going to monitor? Are we going to monitor the new administrative expenditure or what Parliament has passed? I believe that the Minister and the Administrator will have helped themselves if they had included this administrative fiat into the formula. This is the first time and the House should not allow anybody—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Nitiwul, you said this is the first time? I entered this House when you were a Leader and every year, guidelines on utilisation of the Common Fund were issued. This is a House of records.

Mr Nitiwul: Mr Speaker, guidelines are issued not in deviation to what the House itself has passed; that is the difference. If we read exactly what has been said, it is completely different from what this House has passed; that is the difference. Mr Speaker, the guidelines have always been very simple: stick exactly to what the House has passed and the formula. That is exactly what it is. If the Minister had decided to do that, I would not have a problem and that has always been the case.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, I am informed that they are bringing materials towards tomorrow's Message on the State of the Nation. So, you may please conclude.

Mr Nitiwul: Mr Speaker, the point I am just making is that we should not belittle the point that the Minority Chief Whip has made. It is a very serious point

and it boils down to exactly our core business. Because Mr Speaker, if something can be passed in this House and as a Minister, I go outside and do a different thing and the House takes no exception to it, then what is the use of bringing the formula here? Why should we bring the formula? Why should we pass the formula?

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, I urge Colleagues, if they have their phones, they should google the current Local Governance Act 2016, (Act 936). An Act passed by this Parliament. Section 173.

“Power of Minister to give financial instructions.

- (1) The Minister may issue written instructions for the improved control and efficient management of the finances of district assemblies after consultation with the Minister responsible for Finance.
- (2) The instructions may be issued either generally or with respect to particular district assembly and shall be complied with by district assemblies generally or the district assembly concerned.”

So, this law that they passed in this House gives the Minister for Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs the power to issue directives on how to make efficient use of moneys that are sent to them.

The Minister has not changed anything. The formula approved by this

House has two components. Eighty per cent of the money going to the assemblies. The Common Fund is one of the finances of the assembly. Which other fund does the assembly have which is more than the Common Fund?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, please, can we bring a closure to this issue? Conclude.

Mr Nitiwul: Mr Speaker, the District Assembly Fund is not just Common Fund alone. In fact, there is the Common Fund, there is Internally Generated Funds (IGF), there are several funds, there are bonds— *[Interruption]* The Majority Leader is the Leader of the House, I beg him. For Common Fund, the formula of expenditure is passed in this House, but the others are not. So, there is a need for the Minister in consultation with the Minister for Finance to give guidelines as to how IGF and bonds can be spent. Otherwise, the assemblies would just spend it anyhow.

That is what they are talking about. But for Common Fund, it is Parliament that directs the assemblies as to how to spend. That authority is given by Parliament—

2:08 p.m.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, kindly conclude.

Mr Nitiwul: Mr Speaker, all I am saying is that the issue raised by the Member is very serious. That the powers of Parliament are eroded by a new directive that is at variance with what we passed in this House. What do we do?

Are we supposed to let it pass, set a precedent, or pretend that we did not see anything wrong with it? That is the crux of the matter.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well, I will proceed to give the floor to Hon Kwame Agbodza.

Mr Agbodza: I think the point raised by my Colleague is worth listening to when he says that the District Assemblies Common Fund (DACF) utilisation should be looked at. Mr Speaker, the Leader has already indicated. What we did here was legitimate and no one is taking away our powers. We have distributed the percentage of tax revenue that needed to go to the Common Fund administration.

What we have done, which everybody, including my good Friend the Minority Chief Whip, can attest to, is that his Assembly is much more efficient today than ever before. *[Hear! Hear!]* That is on record. Mr Speaker, what are we supposed to be doing? Today, we are saying we should spend 25 per cent on Government flagship projects. Mr Speaker, in 2023, 2024 and 2025, the same DACF deliberately used part of their money to build Astroturf in some constituency. Of course, none was built in my constituency. The district assembly, without any consultation, decided to build something in Adaklu because the Common Fund Administrator decided that that is what should be built in Adaklu. While we had stalled school projects and healthcare projects.

We are saying that, to be fair, spend only 25 per cent to build a market. Which assembly is saying that they do not need a market? We said let us spend 10 per cent on health, 10 per cent on education and all the way down, even spend an amount to continue legacy projects.

Mr Speaker, the fact is that my Colleague was talking about which assembly was wasting money. It is on record that some businesses in this country were built on the fact that whenever tax revenue is collected, they see the pocket of the government as their pocket. When I became an MP, there was this idea of fumigation and cleaning of all assemblies. Mr Speaker, as of that time, the capital of Adaklu, which is Adaklu-Waya, did not even have any tarred road. But there was a deduction from the Adaklu Common Fund towards cleaning the streets and all those things. Where was the street?

Mr Speaker, I took up that issue and confronted that business. They admitted that they deducted money, but they did not do their work. They told us that we should come to their yard and take some equipment equivalent to GH¢200,000. Today, if we go to Adaklu Assembly, the water tanker there was a compensation for the money deducted when the work was not being done. So, when he said that we were squandering the money, I have evidence that is the way they were squandering the money.

Mr Speaker, I agree that if this is what we want to do, then in the next formula, these items could be presented to the Committee of the Whole to be approved.

But to say that what we have done now made the assemblies worse off, no one here, not on this Side, will say that —
[Uproar]

Exactly. Just listen to me. The fact that you and I, can say that our assembly —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Agbodza, kindly conclude.

Mr Agbodza: Mr Speaker, yes, let me conclude. Would they have preferred when assemblies appeared at the Public Accounts Committee and said that they had used money meant for disability for conferences? Is that what they would have preferred? Exactly. Once they agree that the formula is better, I can only say that it is fair to say that, we should just bring the next formula as part of the communication. I do not see anything wrong with it.

Mr Speaker, for the first time, Adaklu District Assembly is not asking me to pay for 6th March. Since I became an MP, every year on 6th March, I would have to buy water for everybody coming there. Because the Assembly Common Fund was in the pocket of only a few businesses. Today, the public purse of the DACF is no longer in a private man's pocket. The money is to be spent in Adaklu, and today, there is money sitting in Adaklu DACF account at NIB, at Ho. In fact, the Common Fund is now common to every assembly. That is what we are talking about. [Hear! Hear!]

Thank you very much.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, I think by an agreement, we have done the two Members on each Side. I intend not to take more. So, let us bring closure to the debate. Hon Members, I intend not to direct that a Committee be formed to investigate any matter. Very soon, the Minister, the Common Fund Administrator, and the team will come before the House for approval of another formula. If you have any inconsistency in the administration of the previous formula, I believe that is the right time for us to pick it up with them, so that they provide a solution as a condition for approving the current formula.

Let us all together hold it when they appear before us for the approval of the 2026 formula, then we could raise the necessary issues at the Committee of the Whole. It is for good reason that matters relating to the formula are discussed at the Committee of the Whole. So, Hon Members, Statement time has ended. Yes, Majority Leader?

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, I think we can take the Motion numbered 10, and then we can take the Motion numbered 11 thereafter.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Minority, the application is the Motion numbered 10.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Maybe the Leader has not been carried along, but I know consultation is ongoing. The Chairperson and the Ranking Member are engaged in a consultation. Until they conclude that consultation, we are unable to accede to that call.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: I think they are back.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, they are back, but they have not communicated. Coming back does not mean yes, so let my Ranking Member communicate to me, then I can communicate same. Mr Speaker, meanwhile, there are other Businesses there —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Minority Chief Whip, certain things are very informal. So, placing those things on record, Hon Minority Chief Whip, I am worried.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, apologies if it did not go down well. However, we will relate to the Ranking Member and do the needful as we should. Leader, but there are other Businesses — we will do all those Businesses, but what about the other Businesses that are lying? Mr Speaker, the Chief Whip is in the House; his Business is there —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Minority Chief Whip, I do not see you being opposed to the current Motion. The Motion numbered 10, Chairperson of the Committee?

MOTION

Suspension of Order 104(1)

Chairperson of the Committee on Finance (Mr Isaac Adongo): Mr Speaker, I beg to *move*:

That notwithstanding the provisions of Standing Order 104(1) which require that a Motion shall not be debated until at least two sitting days have elapsed after the notice to move the motion is given, the Motion for the adoption of the Report of the Committee of Selection on the Composition of the Membership of Committees of the House may be *moved* today.

Chairperson of the Committee on Economy and Development (Mr Eric Afful): Mr Speaker, I rise to second the Motion.

Question put and Motion agreed to.

Resolved accordingly.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: The consequential Motion numbered 11. Chairperson of the Committee?

Report of the Joint Committee on GANRAP 2026-2028

Chairperson of the Committee on Finance (Mr Isaac Adongo): Mr Speaker, with respect, I beg to *move*:

That this honourable House adopts the Report of the Joint Committee on Finance, and Economy and Development on the Ghana Accelerated National Reserve Accumulation Policy (GANRAP) 2026-2028.

In so doing, I present your Committee's Report and invite *Hansard* to capture its entirety while I limit myself to just portions.

Introduction

On Wednesday, 25th February, 2026, the Hon Minister for Finance, Dr Cassiel Ato Baah Forson laid in Parliament the Ghana Accelerated National Reserve Accumulation Policy (GANRAP) 2026-2028.

The Speaker subsequently referred the Policy to the Joint Committee on Finance & Economy and Development for consideration and report in accordance with the Standing Orders of Parliament.

Deliberations

The Joint Committee met with the Hon Deputy Minister for Finance Mr Thomas Nyarko Ampem, the Deputy Governor of the Bank of Ghana, Mrs Matilda Asante Asiedu, the Chief Executive Officer of the Ghana Gold Board, Mr Samuel Gyamfi and Officials of these institutions.

The Joint Committee is grateful to the Hon Deputy Minister and the Officials for attending upon the Joint Committee and assisting in the deliberations.

Reference Documents

The Joint Committee referred to the following documents during the deliberations:

- i. The 1992 Constitution of the Republic of Ghana;
- ii. The Standing Orders of Parliament;
- iii. The Ghana Gold Board Act, 2025 (Act 1140); and

- iv. The Minerals and Mining Act, 2006 (Act 703).

- ii. Inflation had declined sharply to 5.4 per cent, the lowest since August 2013;

- iii. The Ghana cedi strengthened against all major currencies for the first time in over a decade;

Background

Ghana has relied heavily on inflows from gold, cocoa, and crude oil exports to build international reserves. However, over the last decade, the country has relied largely on costly swaps, sale and buy-backs and other short-term facilities as well as Eurobond borrowings to build international reserves resulting in significant debt service obligations. This led to Ghana's unsustainable debt situation in 2022, the resultant debt default and restructuring and subsequent request for an IMF-supported ECF programme in May 2023.

Despite cocoa's historical importance, its contribution to sustained foreign exchange stability has been undermined by price volatility, low productivity, climate risks, and limited value addition.

Crude oil, which initially promised to provide fiscal relief and balance of payments support, is now declining due to lack of investment in the last eight years and waning investor confidence resulting in six years of consistent oil output decline.

The significant fiscal consolidation in 2025, complemented by prudent monetary policy and structural reforms have restored macroeconomic stability. By the end of 2025:

- i. Real GDP growth averaged 6.1 per cent (Q1–Q3), the strongest since 2019;

Trends in Ghana's Reserve Build-Up

A review of Ghana's reserve trajectory reveals a recurring pattern of episodic accumulation followed by drawdowns. Periods of reserve build-up are typically associated with opportunistic external borrowings, such as Eurobond issuances, as well as seasonal cocoa export inflows. These inflows temporarily strengthen the external position and increase import cover.

From a reserve position of 5.4 months of import cover in April 2021, following a US\$3 billion Eurobond issuance, reserves subsequently declined sharply, reaching a low of below 2.3 months of import cover in September 2023.

This depletion reflected significant pressure on Ghana's external buffers amid constrained access to international capital markets, capital outflows, heightened macroeconomic instability, and the need to meet critical foreign exchange obligations.

Overall, Ghana's reserve build-up has historically been cyclical rather than sustained, underscoring the vulnerability of external buffers to external shocks, financing constraints, and macroeconomic pressures.

Policy Objective

The primary objective of the Ghana Accelerated National Reserve Accumulation Policy is to increase Ghana's international reserves to fifteen (15) months of import cover by end-2028 to support long-term structural transformation while safeguarding macroeconomic stability.

To achieve this, the following intermediate targets were set:

- i. Achieve a minimum of 8.6 months of import cover by end-2026;
- ii. Exceed 11.8 months by end-2027; and
- iii. Reach 15 months by end-2028.

These milestones will be reviewed annually based on realised imports, prices, production volumes, and financing conditions.

Strategic Approach

The Policy adopts the following strategic approach:

Gold-Based Reserve Accumulation

The Policy adopts a gold-based reserve accumulation strategy, premised on elevated global gold prices and Ghana's position as a major gold producer. The operational target is the purchase of approximately 3.02 tonnes of gold per week, comprising:

- i. 0.57 tonnes from large-scale mining firms (through pre-emption); and
- ii. 2.45 tonnes from the Artisanal and Small-Scale Mining (ASM) sector through the Ghana Gold Board.

At a projected price of US\$5,000 per ounce. This translates into annual gross receipts of approximately US\$25.28 billion.

Large-Scale Mining Sector Measures

The Minister for Lands and Natural Resources is to invoke the State's pre-emption rights under Act 1140 and Act 703 to acquire at least 20 per cent of large-scale gold output (approximately 0.57 tonnes weekly).

The gold shall be treated as follows:

- i. Purchased in doré form;
- ii. Refined locally;
- iii. Processed to LBMA standards; and
- iv. Added to Ghana's physical gold reserves.

Artisanal and Small-Scale Mining (ASM) Measures

The Ghana Gold Board is mandated to mop up at least 2.45 tonnes of gold weekly from ASM operators. The Board is to:

- i. Arrange sufficient working capital (GH¢15–20 billion equivalent);
- ii. Enter into off-take agreements;
- iii. Deploy hedging and derivative instruments;
- iv. Promote ASM formalisation and traceability;
- v. Support local refining capacity; and
- vi. Implement anti-smuggling price incentives.

The Committee noted that the Ministry of Finance will provide budgetary allocations to support this programme.

Cost–Benefit Analysis

Historical Cost of Borrowing for Reserve Build-Up

Between 2017 and 2024, Ghana borrowed approximately US\$21.7 billion to support reserve accumulation at a combined interest cost exceeding US\$3.84 billion. In addition to GH¢7.3 billion in domestic bond interest costs.

Eurobond issuances between 2018 and 2021 alone cost approximately US\$2.5 billion in interest payments.

Swaps and Sale and Buy-Back (SBB) operations between 2022 and 2024 cost over US\$1.16 billion in interest payments.

Comparative Cost of the Gold Model

In 2025, the Ghana Gold Board reportedly generated approximately US\$10 billion in foreign exchange at a cost of US\$214 million, significantly lower than comparable borrowing costs.

The Committee notes the Policy's argument that gold-backed accumulation reduces debt dependence and enhances sustainability.

Expected Benefits

The Committee acknowledges the macroeconomic improvements recorded in 2025, including; increased reserves to US\$13.83 billion, significant cedi appreciation, reduced inflation and improved debt-to-GDP ratio.

The Committee agrees that sustained reserve accumulation could enhance exchange rate stability; reduce risk premiums, improve investor confidence, strengthen external resilience and reduce reliance on costly external borrowing.

Observations

The Committee made the following observations during the deliberations:

Justification for the GANRAP

The Committee notes the appreciable increase in Ghana's Gross International Reserves to US\$13.8 billion, equivalent to 5.7 months of import cover as at end-2025. The Committee acknowledges this

development as a positive indication of improving external sector conditions and renewed macroeconomic stabilisation efforts.

Notwithstanding this progress, the Committee observes that, within the context of the proposed Ghana Accelerated National Reserve Accumulation Policy (GANRAP), the current reserve level remains below the optimal threshold required to provide strong and sustained self-insurance against external shocks. Ghana's economy continues to exhibit structural vulnerabilities, including dependence on primary commodity exports, exposure to capital flow volatility, susceptibility to global financial tightening, climate-related risks, and regional security uncertainties.

The Committee is therefore of the view that GANRAP is both timely and necessary. A deliberate and rules-based framework for accelerated reserve accumulation will strengthen exchange rate stability, enhance investor confidence, reduce external financing risks, and provide a credible buffer against future balance of payments pressures.

Accordingly, the Committee emphasises that the successful implementation of GANRAP must be anchored on sustained fiscal discipline and primary balance improvements, prudent and coordinated monetary policy management, export diversification and value addition strategies, strengthened foreign exchange inflow mobilisation including remittances and non-

traditional exports, as well as transparent governance and accountability mechanisms for reserve build-up and utilisation. The Committee further underscores the importance of establishing clear medium-term reserve adequacy benchmarks under GANRAP, aligned with Ghana's specific risk profile and external sector dynamics.

Legal, Institutional and Governance Framework for Reserve Accumulation

The Committee observes that the effectiveness and credibility of the Ghana Accelerated National Reserve Accumulation Policy (GANRAP) will depend significantly on the strength of its legal, institutional and governance architecture. A reserve accumulation policy of this nature must operate within a clear statutory framework that defines roles, responsibilities, operational triggers, reporting obligations, and safeguards against discretionary or non-transparent utilisation of accumulated reserves.

The Committee notes that while existing monetary and fiscal management frameworks provide a basis for reserve management, GANRAP introduces a more deliberate and accelerated approach that requires enhanced coordination between fiscal authorities and the monetary authority. In this regard, institutional alignment, policy coherence, and clearly defined operational rules are indispensable to avoid policy conflicts, sterilisation pressures, or unintended macroeconomic distortions.

The Committee further observes that public confidence in GANRAP will be strengthened by robust transparency and accountability mechanisms, including periodic reporting to Parliament, disclosure of reserve accumulation targets and performance outcomes, and independent oversight consistent with best practices in public financial management.

The Committee is therefore of the view that GANRAP should be supported by a clearly articulated governance framework that guarantees operational independence in reserve management while ensuring democratic accountability. Such a framework will reinforce policy credibility, minimise moral hazard risks, and sustain long-term macroeconomic stability.

Role of Local Refineries in Supporting Reserve Accumulation

The Committee observes that the operational efficiency and sustained viability of local refineries are critical to the success of the Ghana Accelerated National Reserve Accumulation Policy (GANRAP). Strengthening domestic refining capacity has direct implications for reducing foreign exchange outflows associated with the importation of refined petroleum products and improving the overall balance of payments position.

The Committee notes that continued reliance on imported refined products places persistent pressure on Ghana's foreign exchange reserves. Revitalising

and optimising the operations of local refineries will contribute to import substitution, reduce exposure to global supply chain disruptions, and moderate exchange rate volatility. Increased domestic refining capacity may also create opportunities for value addition, job creation, and enhanced industrial linkages within the petroleum downstream sector.

Furthermore, the Committee observes that a stable and predictable policy environment for local refineries, including appropriate regulatory oversight, financial restructuring where necessary, and private sector participation, will be essential to ensure operational sustainability and efficiency.

The Committee is therefore of the view that strengthening local refining capacity should be treated as a strategic complementary measure under GANRAP. By reducing structural foreign exchange demand and enhancing domestic value retention, functional local refineries can play a pivotal role in supporting sustained reserve accumulation and broader macroeconomic stability.

Small-Scale Mining and Formalisation of Gold Exports

The Committee observes that small-scale mining represents a significant component of Ghana's gold production and, if effectively regulated and integrated into the formal economy, can substantially support the objectives of the Ghana Accelerated National Reserve Accumulation Policy (GANRAP).

The Committee notes that a considerable proportion of gold produced by small-scale miners has historically escaped the formal export and foreign exchange repatriation channels, thereby limiting its contribution to national reserve accumulation. Weak regulatory enforcement, smuggling, and informal trading structures have resulted in revenue leakages and loss of foreign exchange earnings.

The Committee further observes that strengthening the licensing regime, enhancing traceability systems, formalising gold aggregation channels, and improving oversight mechanisms will enable the State to capture greater value from small-scale mining activities. Incentivising miners to operate within regulated frameworks, coupled with strict enforcement against illegal mining and gold smuggling, will be critical in maximising foreign exchange retention.

The Committee is therefore of the view that the formalisation and effective regulation of small-scale mining should constitute a strategic pillar of GANRAP. By ensuring that gold exports from this segment are properly recorded, repatriated, and channelled through official systems, Ghana can significantly enhance its reserve position while promoting responsible and sustainable mining practices.

Environmental Protection and Sustainable Resource Mobilisation

The Committee observes that the pursuit of accelerated reserve accumulation under the Ghana

Accelerated National Reserve Accumulation Policy (GANRAP) must be balanced with strict environmental protection and sustainable natural resource management principles. While increased gold production and extractive sector performance can enhance foreign exchange inflows, such gains must not come at the expense of long-term ecological stability and public health.

The Committee notes that illegal mining activities, land degradation, deforestation, and water pollution pose significant threats to agricultural productivity, food security, and rural livelihoods. These environmental externalities carry long-term economic costs that may ultimately offset short-term foreign exchange benefits if not properly addressed.

The Committee further observes that sustainable reserve mobilisation requires stronger enforcement of environmental regulations, mandatory land reclamation obligations, improved monitoring systems, and inter-agency coordination among environmental, mining, and security authorities. Compliance with environmental standards should be treated not as a secondary consideration, but as an integral component of macroeconomic resilience.

The Committee is therefore of the view that GANRAP must be implemented within a framework that integrates environmental safeguards, promotes responsible mining practices, and protects critical natural resources. Sustainable economic management demands that reserve accumulation today must not undermine ecological and economic security for future generations.

Institutional arrangements

The institutional arrangements under the Ghana Accelerated National Reserve Accumulation Policy (2026–2028) are structured to ensure clear allocation of responsibilities, legal backing, and coordinated oversight. The Ghana Gold Board is positioned as the operational anchor of the policy, responsible for acquiring gold from the artisanal and small-scale mining sector, entering into off-take agreements, managing trading and hedging strategies, and channelling foreign exchange proceeds to the Bank of Ghana. Its role in enforcing compliance within large-scale mining operations further centralises gold-related transactions under a single institutional framework, promoting coherence but also concentrating operational and financial risk within the entity.

The Bank of Ghana functions as the custodian of the accumulated gold reserves and the manager of liquidity operations. It purchases gold acquired under the pre-emption regime and implements rules-based foreign exchange allocation and sterilisation mechanisms. Importantly, gold acquired under the pre-emption provisions of the Ghana Gold Board Act, 2025 (Act 1140) and the Minerals and Mining Act, 2006 (Act 703) may only be sold subject to prior approval of Cabinet and Parliament. This introduces an additional layer of executive and legislative oversight, reinforcing accountability in the management of strategic reserve assets.

At the coordination level, the establishment of an Inter-Agency Committee co-chaired by the Ministers responsible for Finance and Lands and Natural Resources, with representation from the Governor of the Bank of Ghana and the relevant sector regulators, is designed to promote inter-institutional alignment. The inclusion of enforcement support from state security and anti-illegal mining bodies further integrates governance, compliance, and environmental considerations into the reserve accumulation framework. Overall, the institutional design reflects an effort to balance operational efficiency, central bank control, and democratic oversight, with its effectiveness ultimately dependent on transparency, disciplined execution, and strong inter-agency cooperation.

Funding Arrangements under GANRAP

The funding arrangements under the Ghana Accelerated National Reserve Accumulation Policy (GANRAP) are anchored on a gold-based reserve accumulation framework designed to achieve a target of fifteen (15) months of import cover by end-2028. The Policy requires an average annual net addition of approximately US\$9.5 billion to Gross International Reserves after accounting for debt service, foreign exchange interventions, energy sector payments, and other statutory outflows. Unlike previous approaches that relied heavily on external borrowing, swaps, and sale-and-buy-back arrangements, the Policy adopts a largely self-financing model driven by domestic gold mobilisation and foreign exchange retention.

Central to the funding structure is the weekly acquisition of approximately 3.02 tonnes of gold. Of this quantity, a minimum of 2.45 tonnes per week will be procured from the artisanal and small-scale mining (ASM) sector by the Ghana Gold Board, supported by budgetary allocations from the Ministry of Finance and working capital arrangements estimated at GH¢15–20 billion to ensure continuous market participation. The remaining 0.57 tonnes per week will be acquired from large-scale mining companies through the exercise of Government's pre-emption rights under section 3(d) of the Ghana Gold Board Act, 2025 and section 7 of the Minerals and Mining Act, 2006. This statutory mechanism ensures a guaranteed supply stream to support reserve accumulation.

All gold acquired under the Policy is to be sold to the Bank of Ghana, which will integrate the foreign exchange proceeds into the country's official reserves. The Ghana Gold Board is mandated to sell all foreign exchange accrued under the Policy exclusively to the Bank of Ghana at an agreed cost, thereby ensuring centralised reserve build-up. Furthermore, gold purchased under the pre-emption framework may only be sold by the Central Bank subject to prior approval of Cabinet and Parliament, reinforcing governance oversight and safeguarding the strategic nature of the reserves.

To enhance sustainability and mitigate risk, the Policy incorporates prudent hedging strategies, gold-backed derivative trading within clearly defined risk limits, and robust accounting and audit controls. A liquidity recycling

framework will allow a portion of foreign exchange inflows to be used for targeted market intermediation to smooth exchange rate volatility, while a predefined share will be sterilised to preserve the reserve accumulation trajectory. Collectively, these funding arrangements reposition reserve build-up from a debt-driven model to an asset-backed, rules-based framework aimed at strengthening macroeconomic stability and long-term external resilience.

Sharing of transaction costs

The Joint Committee noted that the policy envisages a negotiated agreement between the Gold Board and the Bank of Ghana to determine the rate at which foreign exchange generated under the programme will be sold. This rate will be formally agreed upon between the Bank of Ghana and Ghana Gold Board.

Cost Sterilisation Measure

The Joint Committee further noted some concerns about sterilisation costs arising from liquidity injections into the system. The Bank of Ghana acknowledged that increased operations may require additional monetary sterilisation measures but indicated that declining policy rates could mitigate associated costs. The Deputy Minister for Finance confirmed that the Government is prepared to share such costs through budgetary support to the Gold Board.

Risks and Mitigation Measures

The Joint Committee observes that while the Ghana Accelerated National Reserve Accumulation Policy (GANRAP) presents a structured and innovative framework for accelerating

reserve accumulation, its successful implementation is subject to a number of identifiable risks. Key among these is price risk arising from potential volatility in global gold markets, which could affect projected foreign exchange inflows and the pace of reserve build-up. Production risk also remains material, particularly within the artisanal and small-scale mining sector, where operational inefficiencies, logistical bottlenecks, and enforcement challenges may undermine weekly acquisition targets. In addition, governance and transparency risks could emerge in the areas of gold procurement, valuation, trading arrangements, and fund management if institutional controls are not rigorously applied. Environmental and social risks, especially those associated with illegal mining and degradation of water bodies and forest reserves, further present reputational and sustainability concerns that could weaken the long-term viability of the policy.

The Joint Committee, however, notes that the Policy outlines mitigation measures aimed at addressing these vulnerabilities. Price volatility is to be managed through prudent hedging mechanisms and gold-backed derivative strategies within clearly defined risk limits. Production risks are to be mitigated through enhanced supervision, modernisation of mining and processing systems, and diversification of production sources. Governance risks are to be addressed through strengthened inter-agency coordination, independent audits, and transparent reporting frameworks, while environmental and social risks are to be tackled through intensified enforcement against illegal

mining, land reclamation initiatives, sustainability programmes, and community engagement. The Joint Committee emphasises that the effectiveness of these mitigation measures will depend on strict adherence to accountability standards, inter-institutional cooperation, and sustained political and administrative commitment.

Traceability of Gold by the Ghana Gold Board

The Joint Committee observes that the introduction of a comprehensive gold traceability framework by the Ghana Gold Board marks a historic and unprecedented development in Ghana's mineral governance architecture. This is the first time that a structured, nationally coordinated system is being implemented to trace gold from the mine to the market, ensuring end to end visibility across the entire gold value chain from extraction to final destination.

The Joint Committee notes that the proposed framework is designed to track gold from the point of extraction through aggregation, assaying, certification, and export. Officials of the Ghana Gold Board informed the Joint Committee that the Board has developed the requisite Terms of Reference for the establishment of the traceability system and will proceed to procure competent vendors to design and operationalise the platform. The Joint Committee was further informed that, following the development of the system, licensed small-scale gold miners and other relevant actors within the value chain

will be onboarded to ensure full participation and compliance.

While the Joint Committee commends this first-of-its-kind initiative, it emphasises that its success will depend on strong enforcement, effective inter-agency coordination, technological reliability, and sustained stakeholder sensitisation. The long-term impact of the framework will ultimately be measured by its ability to enhance transparency, improve revenue assurance, strengthen regulatory compliance, and promote environmental protection within Ghana's gold sector.

Conclusion and Recommendation

The Committee finds that the Ghana Accelerated National Reserve Accumulation Policy (GANRAP) presents a bold and innovative framework to strengthen Ghana's external buffers through gold-based reserve accumulation.

While the Policy carries implementation and governance risks, the Committee is of the view that, with disciplined execution, strong transparency measures, and parliamentary oversight, GANRAP can significantly enhance Ghana's macroeconomic resilience and reduce reliance on costly external borrowing.

The Committee recommends to the House to adopt this Report and approve the Ghana Accelerated National Reserve Accumulation Policy 2026-2028.

Question proposed.

2:18 p.m.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, the Motion has been moved and the Report presented. Any seconder?

Dr Eric Afful (NDC — Amenfi West): I rise to second the Motion.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Member, if you want to contribute, do so.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, we agreed that we take two from each Side and then Leadership will conclude the debate, making it three from each Side.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, let me hear from Hon Habib Iddrisu.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, we had an engagement with the Clerk to Parliament and agreed that due to the fact that tomorrow is the Message on the State of the Nation and the need to prepare the Chamber, we will take three from each Side and then Leadership will conclude.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So, how many minutes are allocated each Member? I need to be guided.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, two from each Side and Leadership will conclude, please.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, that was not the agreement. I have run the agreement with the Majority Leader. There have been a lot of engagements before the Hon Majority Chief Whip came in. So, with respect, we agreed and

we have already presented our list to the Speaker. So Mr Speaker, it is three from each Side and then Leadership will conclude.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So how many minutes is allocated each Member? Is it five minutes each?

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Yes, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So, I will urge the timekeepers to stick to the allocated five minutes.

Yes, we begin with the Hon Eric Afful. Hon Member, you have five minutes.

Mr Eric Afful: Thank you, Mr Speaker for the opportunity to add my voice for the adoption of the Report of the Joint Committee made up of the Finance Committee and the Committee on Economy and Development. I would therefore entreat all Members here, to adopt this Report and approve the policy on Ghana Accelerated National Reserve Accumulation Policy, 2026-2028.

Mr Speaker, this policy has come at the right time when two other drivers of our economy are not doing well on the world market. I am talking about our oil and our golden bean, that is, cocoa. In fact, the prices of these two commodities are volatile and undetermined, and therefore, this policy will save the situation. When we implement this all-important policy, our international foreign reserves, within 2026, will rise to 8.6 months of import cover. It will

exceed 11.8 months of import cover of goods and services by 2027. And the most important aspect of it for which we should all be happy, is that by the year 2028, the import cover will reach 15 months of import cover, which is one year, three months. If you have an economy like this, that gross national reserve is about 15 months of import cover of goods and services, then you are good to go.

Mr Speaker, the Gold for Reserve programme, that we want to intensify, gave us US\$13.83 billion as our reserves in 2025. It covers 5.7 months of import cover. This has improved investor confidence in the country, accelerated stability, and reduced the reliance of external borrowing. This is a good policy we should all agree to adopt and approve.

Mr Speaker, the policy is structured to trace all gold that would be bought in the country. *[Interruption]* Yes, traceability of gold will be done within the year.

Mr Speaker, with these few words, I will implore all Members, especially from the Minority Side to adopt this Report and approve the policy so that we can all grow the economy of Ghana to a certain height in this country.

Thank you so much for the opportunity.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, it is now the turn of Hon Kojo Oppong Nkrumah.

Mr Kojo Oppong Nkrumah (NPP — Ofoase Ayirebi): Mr Speaker, I thank

you for the opportunity to contribute to the Report that has been laid.

I want to start off by quoting a statement that was made by the former Vice President of the Republic, Dr Mahamudu Bawumia, at the launch of the 2024 Manifesto of the New Patriotic Party, when he was giving an update on the performance of the Gold for Reserves and Gold for Forex Programme. He said:

“I am happy to say that the two policies that helped rescue the economy from the catastrophe in the recent crisis were the Bank of Ghana’s Domestic Gold Purchase Programme and the Gold for Oil Programme. The pilot has worked for a number of companies, some of which wanted to take forex out of their jurisdiction. We have thus found a solution to profit repatriation without destabilising our local currency”.

Mr Speaker, he goes on to say that:

“My government will completely institutionalise what I call the Gold for Forex Programme, even as we intensify efforts to transform the structure of the Ghanaian economy. Simply put, the Domestic Gold Purchase Programme is a policy which allows the Bank of Ghana to boost its foreign exchange reserves by buying locally produced gold with cedis”.

And he goes on to talk about the benefits, including the fact that gold will

now become the anchor of the Ghanaian currency.

2:28 p.m.

Mr Speaker, earlier today when we met the Ministry of Finance, the Bank of Ghana and the Gold Board, we put a question to the Governor who was represented by the second Deputy Governor. Is the policy to buy gold to shore up our reserves, be it in bullion or in forex, new? And her answer was categorical; she said no. Mr Speaker, it is a matter of public record that in 2021, the NPP administration came up with the Domestic Gold Purchase Programme, which seeks to ramp up our reserves by using cedis to buy gold and shore up our bullion reserves, or by using cedis to buy gold, trade it for forex and add it to our forex reserves.

Mr Speaker, if therefore a couple of years down the line our Colleagues on the NDC side come to power and they find this policy useful, they do not need to attempt to rebrand it and give it a new name as a Ghana Accelerated National Reserve Accumulation Policy. They do not need to do that. What they need to do is to be candid to the Republic of Ghana and say, we inherited a working programme and probably what we want to do is to build on it. We need candour in economic policy management. Do not try to rebrand it, give it a new name, polish it with some colours and now create the impression that it is something new that they are thinking about.

Mr Speaker, we asked the Government side today what the two

pillars of this gold component are and they told us that they will be using cedis to buy gold to add to the bullion and using cedis to buy artisanal and small-scale (ASM) gold, trade it for forex and add to forex. Mr Speaker, that is gold for reserves and gold for forex. They can turn it, they can bake it, they can cook it, it is still the same thing.

So Mr Speaker, we on this Side will support this policy because what they have done is to continue what was introduced by Dr Mahamudu Bawumia. Mr Speaker, we encourage them that today's voter is sophisticated and understands what is going on. When they introduced the commitment controls, we have commended you that it is actually a good policy. They do not need to go on with this thing where every time, it is settings. Admit it that this is a programme they inherited and they are continuing.

Mr Speaker, the second point I want to make is that what this Government has now announced as a policy demonstrates the confusion in their circles. A few weeks ago, this Government told us that they were of the view that we had so much gold concentration in our reserves and so they have sold 50 per cent of our gold reserves and converted it into U.S. dollar-based assets.

Mr Speaker, there are questions about that transaction already, the timing, the scope and the window with which it was done. And already we have filed Motions to halve that transaction and then the losses on the gold purchase programme properly investigated. Without prejudice

to whatever the outcomes will be, they have now come back to this House that they are asking for policy approval to go and among other things, buy more gold to shore up our reserves. Why would they sell 50 per cent of our gold reserves only to turn around a few weeks later that you want policy approval to go and buy more gold? And by the way, at the time they sold the gold, prices were around US\$4,000. By now, it is somewhere around US\$5,200. So already we have lost about US\$1,000 an ounce on the quantities they sold.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, your time is up. I will proceed to give the floor to Hon Richard Acheampong.

Mr Richard Acheampong (NDC — Bia East): Mr Speaker, thank you very much for the opportunity to contribute to the Report before us. My good Friend, Hon Kojo Oppong Nkrumah used to call on Government to submit policy documents before this House. Today, the document is presented before this House and he has a cause to complain. So, Hon Nkrumah, cannot choose and pick. Mr Speaker, within these few years or months, the Ghana Gold Board has raked in about US\$10 billion. They used to borrow Eurobonds at an average rate of six per cent. Assuming we took a loan of US\$10 billion, we would have paid US\$600 million as an interest. And with this, there is no interest on it.

This is a forward-looking Government. It is projected that by the end of 2028, gold prices will soar up. So, what do we do? Let us take advantage now. So that we

bring the policy document, the House will approve it, and even if they want to liquidate it, they have to go through Cabinet and come to Parliament for approval. They cannot sit in the office and take any decision. They did not do that. And yet they are telling us that they started this programme. What was the end result? What was the level of the appreciation or the depreciation of the cedi?

They implemented all these policies, but the end game was zero. They left inflation at 23.8 per cent. Today it is 3.8 per cent. The cedi has appreciated more than 40 per cent. Instead of patting us on the back, they are here trying to run down the programme. And, Mr Speaker, it is not only the gold. If one checks the document presented to us by the Minister, the Minister talked about Gas-to-Power Programme, Oil Development Programme, Cocoa Reforms Initiatives. All these things are going to be put together to make sure we see a stability. When we were going for the elections, the US dollar was exchanged at GH¢17 and came down to GH¢16. At the time, if one wanted US\$1,000, one needed GH¢17,000. Today, one will need GH¢11,000. That is a GH¢6,000 difference. This is a forward-looking government.

Mr Speaker, it is not about being in opposition and having to criticise everything that the Government is doing. Let us give credit where it is due. Tell us that they could not do it but you thank God that there is a new government in place, which is looking forward and putting in place measures that will yield

positive results. Today, if one goes to the pump, they do not ask you if the person is an NDC or NPP card-bearing member. When one buys fuel, look at it.

Prices of goods and services have dropped. This is what we are talking about. This is the resetting agenda we promised the good people of this country. [*Hear! Hear!*] So, please, if you cannot fight them, you join them. Come and join us. And do not think of winning the next election so that they *pooh-pooh* every programme that we present to them. The NDC has come to stay. [*Hear! Hear!*] And they will remain in opposition with this attitude for a longer period of time. [*Hear! Hear!*] So, Mr Speaker, this is a very positive information given to us. When we met at the Committee, all of them praised the Minister, that it is about time we support this administration to succeed. If the NDC succeeds, Ghana will succeed and the NPP will benefit. So, Hon Kojo Oppong Nkrumah, started it, they could not achieve anything. I do agree with them that Government is continuum but this is the time we are yielding the positive results. We are not using money to dig holes in the name of cathedral. No, we are putting the money where our mouth is.

2:38 p.m.

Mr Speaker, with the traceability thing Hon Afful talked about, they are saying because of the Gold Board we set up, *galamsey* activities will increase. Whether we have the Ghana Gold Board or not, people will still do *galamsey*.

So, let us find a lasting solution to deal with the *galamsey* menace. That is another matter. The GOLDBOD is giving us a positive result. Let us all embrace it and support the Minister for Finance, so that at the end of the day, Ghana will develop and can sustain any shock. We cannot run to the International Monetary Fund (IMF) every time to borrow money and pay interest.

I still have 15 seconds. *[Laughter]* So Mr Speaker, this is a very welcoming news, let us all embrace it. *[Hear! Hear!]*

Mr First Deputy Speaker: I will proceed to give the floor to Dr Amin.

Hon Members, I do not want any confusion. This is the list you gave me, and I am going by it.

Dr Mohammed Amin Adam (NPP — Karaga): Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to contribute to the discussion on the Report.

Mr Speaker, as my Hon Colleague, Hon Oppong Nkrumah, said earlier, we are not against any policy to support reserve accumulation because we know it will help build the resilience of the economy. And so, for that matter, we support this policy. Except that as a responsible Opposition, we need to bring out areas we think are flawed, so that the Minister can address those areas to improve on this policy and its implementation.

First of all, as far as reserves are concerned, this is not the first time we

have built reserves beyond the traditional benchmark of three months of import cover. The traditional benchmark of three months of import cover was exceeded by us in 2024. In fact, we achieved four months of import cover—*[Hear! Hear!]*—amounting to US\$9.6 billion. And so, if they are able to go beyond that, that is an improvement we must acknowledge. But to say this is the first time they are going beyond the traditional three-month benchmark is not true.

Mr Speaker, having said this, the Report indicates that under this programme, the Government would target to buy 127 tonnes of gold annually from small-scale miners. That is worrying for me because, even at lower volumes, they could not achieve their target using traceable gold. They had to resort to buying gold from *galamsey* operators. And this, His Excellency the President, John Dramani Mahama, alluded to. And so, with the level of volumes they are talking about, 127 tonnes annually from small-scale miners, I am afraid our environment is in danger. The lives of Ghanaians are in danger because this Government, as they have done before last year, will resort to buying these volumes of gold from *galamsey* operators, and that is not good for our country.

Mr Speaker, the Report also says that gold reserve-based accumulation can occur with distortions to the domestic market. But that cannot be true because gold reserve accumulation, or reserve accumulation in general, is a balance sheet operation. Therefore, because of

the volumes they are talking about, we are going to see large injections of cedis into the market. But to maintain the levels of inflation we have today, the Bank of Ghana will have to go back using sterilisation to withdraw or mop up this liquidity again. This certainly will lead to distortion. Apart from this, sterilisation has a cost, and at the volumes we are talking about, the cost of sterilisation will be very high. That will lead to losses at the Bank of Ghana. If they are bringing a policy to accumulate reserves, we should have a policy that will not lead to losses at the Bank of Ghana because it distorts the balance sheet. This is why I do not agree with them when they say that they can do gold-based reserve accumulation without distorting the domestic market.

Mr Speaker, in this Report, they also sought to do a comparison between the money that was borrowed to accumulate a reserve between 2017 and 2024, which they said was done at a cost of US\$3.8 billion. This was the interest cost. But today, they are seeking to compare that with the losses that the GOLDBOD recorded when they were selling gold. The losses that occurred at the GOLDBOD as a result of their transaction were US\$214 million. Interest costs cannot be compared with losses. The reality is that the US\$214 million resulting from the US\$10 billion GOLDBOD brought were losses that the IMF alluded to. So, they cannot compare that with interest costs from the borrowing which was done to build a reserve under our Government.

Mr Speaker, the Government must be truthful and transparent, and it must not seek to deceive the people of Ghana

using numbers. The contexts are different. One is interest costs; the other is losses. The Minister, through this policy, is also—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, your time is up. I now give the floor to Atta Issah.

Mr Issah Atta (NDC — Sagnarigu): Mr Speaker, thank you so much.

Let me begin by making this correction that GOLDBOD did not make any loss in 2025. Let me thank the Minister for Finance for this bold policy initiative. They did not make any loss for 2025.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Please continue.

Mr Atta: Mr Speaker, I hope my time will be—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Timekeepers, please stop his time. We are not taking any point of order. We want to have an uninterrupted debate. So, please, let the debate flow. On either Side, I was not taking a point of order. So, let his time resume.

Hon Member, you have the floor.

Mr Atta: Mr Speaker, thank you.

This policy is a shift from the debt-financed reserve accumulation we are used to, to a commodity-anchored reserve accumulation through the GOLDBOD. The objective, as it is already stated in the Report, is to ensure

that in the next three years we achieve 15 months of import cover. The idea of using the buffer-building strategy is aimed at exchange rate stability, inflation control, debt sustainability, and external shock resilience. For a commodity-dependent nation like Ghana, I think this is strategically significant. There is nothing wrong with associating ourselves with good policies. So, let us not blame the NPP if they want to take some of the credit we are getting. But it must be backed by data and facts. Let us look at past regimes and their efforts in terms of reserve accumulation.

Mr Speaker, the extended borrowings through Eurobonds alone, between 2018 and 2021, Ghana issued US\$11.025 billion in the Eurobond market at 7.6 to 9.6 per cent interest. This resulted in high interest payments, increased external debt, vulnerability to global financing lightning, eventual debt distress, and accumulation of reserves in terms of debt.

2:48 p.m.

Mr Speaker, secondly, the short-term effects instruments that they used in terms of increasing their reserve, from 2022 to 2024, they used swaps, sales, buybacks, short-term facilities, and raised US\$5.65 billion in accumulated costs. In interest alone, they paid US\$1.16 billion in interest. This created a rollover risk, hidden quasi-fiscal costs, and artificial reserve deals. In fact, that is what they always talk about when they say the Eurobond is artificial. This is what they did through the swaps, costing this country US\$5.6 billion in terms of short-term debts.

Mr Speaker, on commercial borrowing as a result of an artificial way of making sure that we build our reserves, the New Patriotic Party (NPP) borrowed money from JPMorgan Chase & Co, Standard Chartered Bank, Citi Bank, and they borrowed an amount of US\$2 billion, which became a cost to this country. In an attempt to build reserves, they incurred \$2 billion in interest costs for this country.

Mr Speaker, on portfolios inflows, in 2017, the famous Franklin Templeton, US\$2.25 billion, we ended up paying US\$7.3 billion in interest. So, any attempt they made in terms of reserve accumulation, they incurred costs to the Ghanaian public.

Mr Speaker, why does this differ from the others? First of all, we are moving from debt financing to commodity financing, which is now the global trend. Russia, Australia, and many other countries are moving from debt financing instruments to commodity financing instruments. I heard them say that we depleted 50 per cent of the gold reserves in the Bank of Ghana. We do not keep natural resources forever. We do spotting and hedging properly. Imagine if we had kept the gold at US\$5,000 and today it is sold at US\$500, what would be the value of the solid gold? So, we are moving from debt finance to asset-based accumulation.

Again, we are also reducing the interest burden that they bedeviled this nation with, borrowing or building reserves with an annual rate of 7 per cent to 9 cent extended borrowing costs. We

are successful with this reserve accumulation policy because of the following:

First, because of the strong macroeconomic stability that we are gaining. The reserve rose from about US\$9.11 billion to US\$13.85 billion. The cedi appreciated by 40.7 per cent, which guarantees stability. We also see inflation falling from 33.8 per cent to 3.8 per cent, and then debt fell from about 61.8 per cent to about 45 per cent. So, what exactly are they saying when they say it is their policy?

In conclusion, Mr Speaker, the domestic gold purchase programme is not an NPP policy. In fact, since the central bank was established —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, your time is up.

It is now the turn of Hon Gideon Boako.

Dr Gideon Boako (NPP — Tano North): Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to support this Motion.

Mr Speaker, it is important we are talking about reserve accumulation through commodities, that is, gold, at this time, because, as we all understand, history has taught us that from the time of President Kufuor where Ghana made its first appearance in the Eurobond markets, all successive governments, from Professor Mills to President Mahama to President Akufo-Addo, have gone to the Eurobond market. So, until we got the knowledge and understanding to use

gold to back our currency and our reserves through the instrumentality of the former Vice President, Dr Mahamudu Bawumia, previous governments had resorted to the Eurobond market to accumulate reserves.

Mr Speaker, it is important to stress that the lowest rate of interest for entering the Eurobond market by Ghana was realised during the period of the previous government. During the period of the National Democratic Congress (NDC) government, we had higher rates of interest. So, if anybody has a cause to worry as to how much interest Ghana had incurred or paid as a result of patronising the Eurobond market, that was recorded during the period of the NDC.

Mr Speaker, it is important that as we are discussing this reserve accumulation, we understand what this policy stands on. This policy stands on two main pillars. One, gold to be bought by the Bank of Ghana in reserve, that is gold for reserves. And then gold to be bought and then changed into dollars, that is gold for reserves.

Mr Speaker, this reminds us of what has happened before. This gold accumulation policy, *mutatis mutandis*, is the same as the gold for reserve policy that was instigated during the period of the NPP. What has changed in actual sense is how this Government intends to do that, and I have a fundamental problem with that. We are talking about reserve accumulation and reserve management that fall directly under the purview of the central bank of Ghana. But what do we see today? This policy is

presented to this House by the Minister for Finance. This is clearly a breach, an administrative overreach. We are seeking to capture the mandate of the independence of the central bank, and that is not right.

Mr Speaker, if we go through this policy and we read paragraph 43(1), it talks about the fact that there is going to be a Central Committee that will be chaired by the Minister of Lands and Natural Resources and the Minister of Finance. It does not even give the Central Bank, which has the sole mandate for reserve accumulation and reserve management, a seat at the top of this committee. This is not right.

Mr Speaker, again, this report also talks about the fact that “the gold shall only be sold by the central bank subject to prior approval of Cabinet and Parliament”. This is not right. This is an administrative overreach. The gold that is going to be kept by Ghana as reserve is the direct mandate of the central bank of Ghana. I understand, and I know that it is an attempt by this Government to capture the resources of the state, and this Government is doing that through this policy. We should not allow the Executive arm of Government to dictate the path of our reserve accumulation and decide when and how our reserves must be sold for forex in this country; that is not right.

Mr Speaker, it is also important that as we talk about this. This whole document from page one to the end, when we go to the content, it allocates costs and benefits to be treated under pages 19 and 20. I

have gone through this document, and there is not a single mention of how much this is going to cost the people of Ghana; we need to know.

Mr Speaker, come to think of it, who is talking about reserve accumulation? There is a Twi adage that *kwatirikwa se ɔbe ma wo ntoma aa, tie ne din*, to wit, if a naked man promises you a cloth, you need to listen to the name of that person.

This very Government came to meet reserves of over US\$9 billion. They came to meet the gold accumulation reserve of over 32 tonnes, they sold 18 tonnes plus US\$10 billion of gold through the Gold Board, which adds up to US\$13 billion. Out of this US\$13 billion, only US\$4 billion is realised in our reserves. Where is the gold? Where is the forest? Where are the reserves? So today, if they come back to tell us that we should give them a mandate to buy gold for reserves, what is the trust? Where is the credibility? The ones they came to —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Leadership?

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, we will yield to our senior Colleague, Hon Kobby.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Kobby, you have the floor.

Mr Kwabena Okyere Darko-Mensah (NPP — Takoradi): Thank you very much, Mr Speaker, for this opportunity.

Mr Speaker, I believe that this programme, as rightly said, is an NPP programme that the NDC is trying to capture, claim and also hide their own inefficiencies in this programme.

First and foremost, we all know what has gone on with this programme under the NDC, with the large losses of over US\$240 million to the state.

2:58 p.m.

Mr Speaker, one key area that I want to dwell on is the issue of the sourcing programme. First and foremost, we are told about bonuses and discounts and the question I want to ask on this is why is Government paying discounts and bonuses? First and foremost, if anybody is buying gold from any market, all they do is that the person paying money because he is buying large quantities is given a discount, more as a profit. When he sells the gold outside, he also makes profit. So why is it that in this case, the Government of Ghana, under the GoldBod, is paying discounts to somebody who is actually selling the gold to him? Clearly, Mr Speaker, this is criminal and I believe that they want to use this policy to authorise that criminality and that illegality.

Mr Speaker, it is very fundamental that if this is a public policy, this is going to be a cost to the State and it is one of the reasons we lost US\$214 million. If this is a policy, that part should be struck out of this policy.

Mr Speaker, the Bank of Ghana and the Government is clearly a monopoly.

They set the prices. If they are setting the prices, under what circumstances are they setting prices to make losses and go and pay another bonus? Clearly, this is criminal and we need to look at it and strike it out of this policy.

Mr Speaker, going forward, we are also being told that there is going to be a traceability mechanism. So, so far in the last one year, they have not done any traceability, clearly showing their incompetence and inefficiency in managing this programme. Mr Speaker, as we speak, the target is to buy a minimum of US\$20 billion worth of gold every year. Where is the money coming from? Is the Governor going to print money to pay for it or Ghanaians are going to be taxed to pay for it? Because the first Budget that was read by Hon Ato Forson, he mentioned that he was going to make available in excess of US\$200 million to the GoldBod to be buying the gold, which meant that that was going to come from our taxes. So far, it has not been indicated anywhere here where those moneys would be coming from. So, I believe that, if the NDC has a major agenda to accumulate gold, nobody stops them because the fundamentals of that gold purchase programme have already been laid for Gold for Forex and also Gold for Reserves.

So, Mr Speaker, if the NDC wants to be accumulating gold, what is their track record? Last year, we did four months of import cover for reserves. They have only added 1.6 months of import cover. So, if we are looking at their record for the next three years, we are only looking at 10 months of import cover and not the

15 months of import cover. I believe that they only brought these documents to us so that they can be seen to be doing something and they can hide under it and be paying these bonuses and the discount to themselves and go and share. This clearly, if we are not careful, is going to lead to a phenomenon of create, loot, and share. We have to be very careful with the policy we are implementing. We need to take that part out of this policy. We need to take that part out because the market, when it works, it works so well and it has been working so well. We cannot allow officialdom to be added to this document to protect that criminality that we suspect is going to come from this paper.

Mr Mahama Ayariga — *rose* —

Mr Darko-Mensah: Mr Speaker, as for policy, we know that the Governor of Bank of Ghana has the right in determining monetary policy. We also know that the Bank of Ghana has a developmental responsibility as well. They have been doing it already. So, there is nothing new under the sun that this policy is bringing, apart from giving us some fantasy for us to quickly get hooked on to and they will use their discounts and their artificial bonuses to create, loot, and share.

Mr Speaker, with these few words, I would like to thank you for the opportunity. [*Hear! Hear!*]

Deputy Minister for Finance (Mr Thomas Nyarko Ampem) (MP): Mr Speaker, I want to thank you for this opportunity and to thank Hon Members

for their contribution in support of this wonderful policy. I have listened to them, and clearly one thing runs through their contribution. They all support this policy. That is the most important thing. As to try to take credit about the genesis of this policy and all that, I would not have wanted to dwell on that, but Mr Speaker, since Ghana became Ghana, we have always used gold to support our reserve accumulation. It has always been the case that Ghana would use gold, would use cocoa to build reserves. When they say that during their term, they used gold to build reserves, nobody has said that that never happened. What we are doing today is to introduce a clear policy that will have a coordinated means to build reserves to unprecedented levels. [*Hear! Hear!*] Levels that Ghana has never seen before. That is the difference.

Mr Speaker, I listened to them. I just want to respond to a few of the things that they said. My friend Gideon Boako was questioning why the committee that will lead in the pre-emption of the gold is chaired by the Minister for Lands and Natural Resources and not the Governor. Mr Speaker, this House passed the Minerals and Mining (Amendment) Act, 2019, and we passed the Ghana Gold Board, 2025 (Act 1140). In fact, Section 7 of the Minerals and Mining Act 2006 (Act 703), says the Minister has the right of pre-emption of all minerals raised.

The authority to invoke the pre-emption right is given to the Minister for Lands and Natural Resources. We cannot bypass him and go and give the power, through a policy, to any other person apart from the person who has been

given that authority by the laws of this land to do so. That is as simple as that.

He also questioned why we are recommending through this policy that if we decide to liquidate gold that is purchased through this programme, it should go through Cabinet and come to Parliament. It is to enhance transparency and to allow Ghanaians to have a say in the assets that we are going to accumulate. Are they not happy that we are bringing it to Parliament? We those who are calling for better transparency for the people's representatives to actually have a say in how we do this, they are now turning back to question us. Mr Speaker, in fact we do not want to do anything in secrecy. We want to do it *fiily-fiily*.

Mr Speaker, another thing that they mentioned was that it is because we want to do state capture. Everybody in this country knows the regime that wanted to practise state capture in this country. They cannot describe us as a regime that is interested in state capture.

Mr Speaker, I heard others also mention a name here, that this policy was introduced by Dr Bawumia. Not too long ago, we heard somebody saying he was the driver's mate and that he was not responsible for anything that happened within the eight years. Today, they are trying to mention the name of the driver's mate, that he is becoming the driver. No, do not do that. Do not do that because it will not wash.

Mr Speaker, let me come to the substantive issues. If we look at this policy clearly, it is a gold-led reserve accumulation policy. It is not focusing only on gold. In fact, if we look at page 18 of the policy, it says that Government will deepen structural reforms that expand foreign exchange inflows while reducing persistent FX outflows. We have listed a number of things: enhancement of non-traditional exports, cocoa sector recovery—Today, cocoa prices have plummeted—

3:08 p.m.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Deputy Minister, your time is up.

Question put and Motion agreed to.

Resolved accordingly.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, we have sat beyond five hours. Fortified by Standing Order 56 (2), I will proceed to adjourn the House—

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, when we were about to present the Business Statement, we did not really have a lot of MPs in the Chamber, so we had agreed that when we are about to adjourn, we would draw the attention of Members to the attachment to the Business Statement dealing with the Message on the State of the Nation. This is because there are some updates there regarding when Members should be in the Chamber.

The update is that we should all be in the Chamber no later than 8:30 a.m. If Hon Members do not enter the Chamber before 8:30 a.m., when the President arrives, Hon Members would not be allowed into the Chamber. The President is going to be on schedule, so that is something that I thought must be communicated to Members. Members should please share with those who are not here. I have a screenshot of this that I have put on the platform of the Majority Caucus. I will urge my Colleagues opposite if they can also screenshot the update on the Message on the State of the Nation. It is attached to the Business Statement. Make a copy available to Members on the platform so that even those who are far away will make sure they get here.

Also, Hon Members are urged to go through security screening. Because the President is coming into the Chamber, and many other dignitaries, ambassadors, former Presidents *et cetera* are coming in, there is a decision that even Members will be screened. So, Members are going to go through the security screening like any other person. Screening of Members will definitely take place.

Also, the parking of vehicles. Where we normally park our vehicles, that is the MP's car park, will not be available. If we would all recall, that is where the security agencies rehearse and then finally troop to the frontage of the Chamber block for the Guard of Honour. So that car park will not be available. Hon Members are all entreated to park at the space by the Member Centre. That is where the tent is.

Finally, the Speaker's Lobby is out of coverage area tomorrow. No Member of Parliament is permitted into the Speaker's Lobby tomorrow. So please, Members should take note that the Speaker's Lobby, where the Speaker meets and then proceeds into the Chamber is out of coverage area for all Members of Parliament tomorrow. I think those are the main guidelines for tomorrow, and I thought to communicate this before Mr Speaker adjourns the House.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, if the Majority Leader says Members should be seated by 8:30 a.m. that needs to be communicated to the Marshall Department so that they will actually open the Chamber early and Members will come and sit. But, if the Majority Leader says we should do all this preparation and all this arrangement for the Message on the State of the Nation, we already know the state of the nation, that there is haircut to cocoa farmers, that there is unemployment, that we are suffering in this current state of the economy. Electricity prices are skyrocketing, people cannot buy electricity, and all that.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Habib Iddrisu, you are completely out of order.

ADJOURNMENT

The House was adjourned at 3:12 p.m. till Friday, 27th February, 2026 at 10:00 a.m.

